between the shelves

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between the shelves

by arlelynx

Summary

“Please don’t slam the books.” A stern voice cuts through the stillness.

Phainon jumps in fright, clutching at his chest to will his heartbeat to slow as he turns to face the person who interrupted his brooding. As soon as he takes in what’s before him, he forgets how to think.

A man stands across from him, arms folded neatly across his chest, watching him behind a pair of simple black frames that suggest he’s already written Phainon off as a lost cause. He’s sharp and poised, biceps bulging even beneath his loose-fitting jumper, and the worn edges of the neckline leave a sliver of his clavicle on display that Phainon can’t seem to look away from.

--

or, in another life, come and visit me at my library.

Chapter 1: chapter one

Chapter Notes

omg hi everyone here's my first contribution to the phaidei fandom! ☀

it's my first chaptered fic in a looong time, so i'm quite nervous to post this v_v i desperately need a phaidei romcom in my life, so here's the start of it~

unedited, so there will probably be mistakes, sorry about that. i also have never been to university so i don't know how it all works, most of this is just made up to fit the plot!

anyway, enjoy (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The library smells of old paper and dust - like knowledge, like expectations. All of which Phainon isn’t living up to in his current state of affairs. It’s woven into the worn leather spines and the yellowed pages of books that have passed through countless hands, and now into his. There’s something quietly reverent about it, something heavy, as though the weight of every unread word presses against the silence. The scent lingers in the air, tickling his nose as he withholds another sneeze from the particles floating around.

Phainon never spends much time here. Not because he doesn’t appreciate knowledge - he *does*, or he wouldn’t be bothering to pursue an engineering degree - but because he prefers learning by doing rather than reading. Words on a page feel static, unmoving, detached from reality, whereas when things move, they are tangible enough to touch and build, and that’s when he thrives. But here, in the vast stillness of the library, where he’s afraid to breathe too loudly, everything exists in a world of paper or laptop screens.

It’s far too quiet. Phainon isn’t used to not having constant background noise, whether that’s in the form of a low hum of life happening around him, friends chatting, coffee machines whirring, or even music playing through his headphones. Here, the only sounds are the occasional rustling of pages, the quiet *click click* of keyboards, the distant scratch of a pen and the rhythmic tick of the grand old clock mounted on the wall above him. It’s the kind of silence that demands something of you, that makes you hyper-aware of every inhale, every shift in your seat, every absent-minded tap of your fingers against the desk.

The dim glow of antique desk lamps casts long shadows across the rows of bookshelves, stretching between towering aisles like pathways to another world. It makes the library seem gloomier than it actually is, considering it’s daylight outside. Phainon feels like he’s stuck in a relic of another era - heavy oak tables, worn-out chairs, the faint creak of floorboards beneath careful steps. It’s the kind of place that whispers rather than speaks, that judges you for being too loud, too restless, too alive.

Phainon exhales, slumping over the open book in front of him, no longer caring if he disturbs the stillness. He hates this - *despises* it, in fact - but if he wants to pass this module, he’s going to have to focus. Yet when he tries to do just that, the words on the page begin blurring together, diagrams no longer making any sense as he stares at them. He could use his laptop, but the thing barely works on a good day, let alone using the public wifi available. His assignments are due at midnight tomorrow, which leaves him plenty of time, but not when he’s spending most of it ruminating on how much he’d rather be anywhere else. All his friends are busy doing their own things, such as *living their lives*, free of assignments because they don’t put them off until the last minute like he does. It’s his fault, but it doesn’t make the knowledge any easier to swallow.

Frowning, he sits up again, glaring down at the book like that'll fix everything. He shoves his hand underneath the front cover, flipping it shut in a childish outburst of spite.

"Please don't slam the books." A stern voice cuts through the stillness.

Phainon jumps in fright, clutching at his chest to will his heartbeat to slow as he turns to face the person who interrupted his brooding. As soon as he takes in what's before him, he forgets how to think.

A man stands across from him, arms folded neatly across his chest, watching him behind a pair of simple black frames that suggest he's already written Phainon off as a lost cause. He's sharp and poised, biceps bulging even beneath his loose-fitting jumper, and the worn edges of the neckline leave a sliver of his clavicle on display that Phainon can't seem to look away from. There's something tattooed on his skin, swirling and red, that captures his attention more than the textbook in front of him ever did. It contrasts with the muted colour of his jumper, which looks so soft it could be wool or even cashmere.

Distantly, Phainon notices the lanyard looped around his neck, an ID card hanging from the end of it. The plastic catches the glow of the desk lamp, reflecting a faint gleam as it sways, practically begging him to take a look. Without thinking, Phainon leans forward, his curiosity outweighing his better judgement. The tiny, pixelated photo on the card shows the same sharp gestures now illuminated before him - blonde hair tousled just enough to suggest some form of styling goes into it, amber eyes caught in an impersonal, official stare. Even in a low-resolution ID photo, he looks striking.

There’s a block of text beside the image, too small to make out in the dim light, but two words stand out, bold and capitalised, demanding attention: *HEAD LIBRARIAN*. Phainon expected something else, maybe a *security guard* going by the guy’s well-defined build and height. The title feels no less weighty, as though he’s just met the king of the castle. This guy isn’t just anyone, clearly. Phainon jolts, realising too late that he’s been obvious with his staring. The moment stretches, thick with words unspoken before he forces himself to look away, suddenly hyper-aware of the stillness between them. He swallows, his throat dry as if the air itself has changed - charged with something he can’t quite understand. His cheeks flush as he laughs nervously, trying to break up the awkwardness that he created. It doesn’t help that he feels severely underdressed, suddenly conscious of how terrible he probably looks in comparison: running on nothing but coffee and a quick nap, dressed in a bright yellow t-shirt paired with a pair of purple shorts.

He should really say something. Apologise, probably, and make a joke that he didn’t realise that he’d slammed the book closed at all. Maybe, he could even ask for help to see if there are any other materials the library holds that could aid him. Unfortunately, he does none of that, his brain short-circuiting instead, struck dumb by the realisation that he finds this stranger - this disapproving, clearly no-nonsense librarian - unreasonably attractive.

“Right, yeah. Sorry.” Phainon finally stutters out, clearing his throat and trying to shake off the ridiculous thoughts going around his head.

The librarian doesn’t respond, electing to only give him a slow, assessing blink before turning away, and walking back to where Phainon presumes the front desk is. Just like that, he’s been dismissed, probably never to be

taken seriously ever again. Phainon sighs, dragging a hand through his hair, cringing at how oily his roots feel.

Maybe it’s time to just go home.

Phainon has no intention of going back to the library the next day. He assures himself it’s because the place is suffocating - too quiet, too serious, too full of books he’ll never understand - but deep down, he knows it’s because of *him*. The librarian. The one with the sharp gaze and the unreadable expression. The one who barely looked at him and yet somehow managed to make him feel like a complete idiot with a single sentence.

It was stupid, really. Hardly the most humiliating thing he’s ever done - especially considering he’s still best friends with Castorice, who has witnessed nearly every mortifying moment in his life since they were kids. She was there when he tripped on stage during a school assembly in Year 9, sprawled flat on his face in front of the entire school population. She was there when he spent three whole weeks convinced his physics teacher had a personal vendetta against him, only to realise that she hadn’t been glaring at him at all, but instead squinting due to her bad eyesight. She was even there when he’d had his first kiss with a girl in his class behind the bike shed, sitting with Castorice afterwards on the floor of his bedroom, eating crisps straight from the packet while he swore up and down it wasn’t *that* good, honestly. And yet, despite a history filled with moments that should have been far more embarrassing, this one clings to him the most. It’s not as though the librarian was cruel or dismissive, he hadn’t even stuck around long enough for that, yet still, the encounter leaves a lingering heat in his chest whenever he thinks about it. Which, considering how little time has passed since it happened, has been *a lot*.

Castorice would tell him he's overreacting. She'd roll her eyes, shove a biscuit dipped into tea into his mouth, and tell him to get over himself. Normally, she's the first person he tells everything - every triumph, every disaster, every stupid, fleeting moment in between despite the physical distance between them due to attending different universities. She's the one who gets the first text at an ungodly hour after he gets into an argument with his parents (*i'm coming over, unlock ur door pls*), to the moment he called her when he got his acceptance letter for engineering at his dream university. She knows *him* - the unpolished, unfiltered, messy version of him that no one else gets to see. And yet, despite all that and more, he can't bring himself to bring up their text conversation and type a simple *so i met a guy*.' All that'd do would open a can of worms he hasn't even begun to do himself, to delve deeper into the stranger in the library with the cool, unreadable gaze, the one who made his stomach twist in a way he's never felt before.

It should be easy to mention - just another one of his passing stories that they exchange daily in their text conversations, another stupid thing to laugh about over coffee, perhaps, but every time he thinks about saying it, the words never make it into reality. Phainon guesses it could also be because there's not much to tell. Like, *oh, the librarian on campus probably hates me bc i slammed closed one of his precious books, lol*. But none of that encompasses all the other unnecessary feelings he's been saddled with alongside it.

So, for his own sake, and possibly for his sanity, too, he stays away.

He finds other places to study instead, bouncing from one spot to the other in a futile attempt to settle. Even his dorm room isn't quite *right*, leading to another bout of restlessness that makes him feel jittery all over. He chooses

to go to the café near campus first. He thought he was used to noise, usually revelling in the sounds of clattering of cups and the constant murmur of conversation, but now it makes him feel uneasy. The next spot he goes to, lugging his textbooks and laptop bag strung over one shoulder, is the student lounge. Somehow, it’s even worse. He knew there was a reason he’d stopped frequenting it a week after he started uni - and it seems that reason hasn’t changed: there’s always someone playing terrible dubstep music from a half-broken speaker at any given time. To get any work done here would require an unreal amount of concentration and dedication, both of which he’s currently lacking. His last choice is the common room, which should’ve been a reasonable alternative, but proves useless when he finds himself too easily pulled into side conversations with his fellow students, too eager for distractions that let him ignore the growing anxiety clawing at his chest.

None of these places are good for concentration, and he’s not entirely sure how he managed before studying there during the past 2 years. Defeated, he makes his way back to his dorm room, grumpy and overstimulated from a wasted day.

As Phainon clicks *Submit* on his second to last assignment - the clock turning from 7:59 pm to 8:00 pm, he catches himself thinking about the library again. Or, more specifically, the person *in* the library. There’s a small amount of relief at almost being done for the week in catching up with his work, but it’s overtaken by more aimless thoughts. Phainon wonders if he’d even recognise him if he went back, or if he’s already erased him from his memory, just another nameless student making noise when they shouldn’t. He should be grateful he didn’t care. He should be relieved that he probably hasn't spared him a second thought. Instead, the idea of being forgotten gnaws at him in a way he can’t explain.

Frustration bubbles over as he stares blankly at his laptop screen, the words *You have successfully submitted your assignment* blurring together as though it's a mass equation he can't get his head around. He needs to focus, needs to study, needs to stop spiralling over some librarian who he's only met once. The longer he sits there, the extent of what he needs to do weighing on his shoulders, the *0% Completed* next to his last assignment feeling like a hole in his head, the more obvious it becomes. He can't keep pretending to avoid the library as though it's helping him. He isn't getting anything done. And as much as he wants to deny it, the truth is inescapable: right now, the library is the best place to finish his work. Phainon just has to suck it up and go back. He's a big boy, fully grown and well into adulthood, surely he can brave it one more time? Maybe it'll scratch this itch once and for all, and then he can go about living his life as he'd done before.

It's fine, anyway - it's not like he *has* to interact with the librarian. Easy: he'll keep his head down, find a quiet corner far, far away from the front desk, and actually get his work done. That's all. No ridiculous overthinking, no pointless distractions, and thank the gods, no dubstep music to be heard.

With that in mind, and with a quick glance at the clock - it's now 8:30 pm, which means he'll have a few hours to finish this final assignment before the deadline ends - he shoves his laptop into his bag and collects his textbooks, pulling on a varsity jacket as he heads out across campus before he can talk himself out of it.

It only takes a few minutes to get from his dorm to the library, but tonight, the walk feels different. The crisp evening air is a relief after spending hours holed up in his room, where the walls seemed to press in, thick with the stale scent of unfinished coffee and the weight of unproductive studying. Out here, the cool breeze sharpens his senses, brushing against his

warm skin, coaxing him to wake up and giving him enough energy to continue for the rest of the night. Phainon isn't against pulling all-nighters, but considering how late he'd left his assignments, he doesn't have that choice: once the clock hits midnight, it's all over for him.

He inhales deeply, the air clean with the distant scent of damp earth and fallen leaves. Autumn time is one of his favourites, the campus turning into a rich mix of yellow and orange hues, the trees turning bare ready for the winter months. The pathways are busy despite the late hour, clusters of students weaving past him, some laughing and some lost in their own worlds, faces illuminated by the glow of their phone screens. The faint hum of conversations and rhythmic tapping of his shoes against concrete creates a familiar soundtrack to campus life at night: active, yet subdued, a transition between the chaos of the day and the quiet evening.

Phainon walks quickly, hands shoved in his jacket pockets, his breath coming out in soft clouds in the chill. He tells himself he's in a rush because he needs to study, needs to make the most of this new-found awakeness, the final hours before the deadline ticking down at an alarming rate. The library will welcome him as it always has - with its dim golden lighting and the scent of polished wood, allowing him to work in peace. Shaking the thought of the blonde man away before it can begin, he quickens his pace, his trainers scuffing against the pavement. The sooner he gets there, the sooner he can get this over and done with.

The moment he steps through the heavy oak doors of the library, the now familiar scent of old paper and dust once again washes over him, grounding and suffocating all at once. The air inside is a lot thicker than the brisk breeze outside, the contrast sending goosebumps across his arms as he

shivers. He bolsters himself, straightening his spine and holding his head high. He has a right to be here! This is *his* university campus, and the only library on site, of which he's perfectly entitled to use regardless of anything else. Albeit he hadn't made much use of it in the past, but he can turn over a new leaf, can't he? He can find the appeal in the quietness, the silent comradery of the other students focusing on their tasks too, headphones on and locked in.

Phainon's confidence holds for approximately five seconds - right up until his gaze drifts towards the front desk and lands on *him*. He's sitting back in an office chair, legs spread wide, flipping through a thick hardcover. The glow of the desk lamp casts long shadows across the multitude of angles of his face, highlighting the lines of his cheekbones, the elegant slope of his nose, and the precise cut of his jaw. It turns each feature into something almost sculptural, like what he'd seen at the local history museum in the marble sculptures from the Greek period. His glasses have slid slightly down the bridge of his nose, and when he pushes them up absentmindedly with his forefinger, Phainon's eyes follow the motion without thinking.

There's something effortlessly composed about him, an air of solitude and coolness, striking in the way his expression remains neutral and focused, as if nothing in the world could shake him. It only makes his beauty more infuriating, and almost affirms the stirring emotions it'd caused Phainon yesterday. It isn't the kind that demands attention, loud and obvious - it's the kind that sneaks up on you, refined and deliberate, like the pages of a rare book worn smooth at the edges but still pristine beneath careful hands.

He should step away, go and find that desk in the corner of the room, far away from the front desk just like he'd promised himself. But for a brief, stupid moment, he forgets why he's there. His mind blanks, caught on the curve of the librarian's downturned lips, the way the light grazes the side of his throat and dips into the hollows of his exposed collarbones, those

curious red tattoos peeking through the top few buttons of an undone shirt. The guy is unfairly pretty in a rugged type of way, where the handsomeness of his face and built body should take precedence over anything else and yet can't compare to the delicate way his eyelashes flutter against the highs of his cheekbones.

A beat passes, and Phainon's chest tightens, the feeling unfamiliar and unwelcome. He swallows hard, and he should keep his mouth shut, but he's walking up to the front desk before he can stop himself. His pulse ticks unreasonably fast, and he tells himself it's just because he's sleep-deprived and only running on the latte and croissant he had early this morning during his brief stint at the cafe, and not because the librarian still hasn't noticed him, completely absorbed in whatever he's reading.

He clears his throat, dumping his bag onto the front desk with a *clack*, his laptop hitting the wood.

Big mistake.

The librarian glances up, eyes narrowed in clear annoyance at the disturbance, and now Phainon actually has to speak. Shit, he hadn't planned this far ahead.

"Uh, hey," His voice comes out slightly hoarse, so he clears his throat again, and then immediately regrets it when the librarian arches a single, perfectly unimpressed brow at his entrance.

“...Can I help you?” He asks, tone as measured and calm as the day before.

Phainon nods, his head lolling up and down like a muppet. He realises he’s going to have to answer that with more than a gesture. “Yeah, I just - um, I need to return this.” He lifts the textbook in his hands as proof, gripping it far too tightly. He doesn’t need to return it at all, it’s *his damn book*, one that he had to pay out of his yearly tuition allowance. This is the most stupid, ridiculous, embarrassing thing he’s ever done, and yet: “Since, you know, that’s… what libraries are for.”

The librarian blinks at him, his head tilting ever so slightly, the braid in his hair swinging gently from the movement. “That *is* what libraries are for, yes.”

Phainon wants to die. Right here, right now, between the bookshelves, crushed beneath the weight of his incompetence to act like a normal human being. But no, he keeps going, because apparently, he’s incapable of cutting his losses. In for a penny, in for a pound, right? He robotically dumps the book onto the counter, waiting with bated breath as the librarian slowly puts down the hardback in favour of Phainon’s. The guy looks up at him sceptically before picking it up, flipping it open to check the borrowing slip. Only, with the dawning realisation on both of their faces, there *isn’t* one. Instead, there’s a slightly crumpled-up receipt from a secondhand bookshop tucked inside the dust jacket.

The librarian’s gaze lifts back to him, completely unreadable. “This isn’t a library book.”

Phainon frowns, his brain scrambling to process the words. “What?”

The librarian sighs sharply, as though inconvenience beyond belief, which Phainon supposes he technically is, and turns the book around, tapping the inside cover with his knuckle. “There’s no stamp. No borrowing record. This is *your* book.”

Phainon stares. Then, because he’s stupid and his brain is still unable to comprehend anything, he blurts out: “No, it’s not.”

A pause. The librarian looks pointedly at the receipt. *Phainon’s* receipt, with his name and tutor group number scrawled across the top.

“Oh,” He says, voice hollow, “Oh, my *god*.”

Heat floods his face as the full weight of his stupidity crashes down on him like a bucket of ice water. He tries to think of a way to salvage this, but there *is no way*. He’s doomed. He has just marched up to the hot librarian and tried to return a book that he personally owns, one that he *knew* he owned. He wishes the dark brown flooring would open up and swallow him whole.

The librarian, to his credit, doesn’t laugh. His expression hardly changes, but there’s something suspiciously close to amusement lighting his eyes. “Did you mean to return another book?”

Phainon shakes his head, dazed. “No. I - I think I just -” He gestures vaguely at the air as if that explains anything. “I wasn’t… paying attention.”

“Clearly.” The librarian snaps the book shut with a sense of finality and hands it back, their fingers brushing together for the briefest moment. The touch is cool, steady - completely unfazed - unlike Phainon, who feels he might combust into smithereens.

He takes the book back too quickly, practically snatching it away and nearly dropping it in the process. He grips it like it’s suddenly a live grenade, and it might as well be considering he’d just about blown up any confidence he had left in this exchange. Phainon needs to leave, like, immediately, but he also needs to study and finish his assignment.

“Okay, well, I’ll just - um - go.”

The librarian inclines his head in a quiet farewell, not even deigning Phainon with a vocal response, and without a word, returns back to the book he’d been reading before this disaster occurred as if it never happened. Phainon turns on his heels, the soles of his trainers squeaking horrendously loud against the polished floor, and speed-walks toward the corner of the room. Just as he’s about to be out of earshot, he catches the faintest sound from behind him. A breath - not quite a laugh, more of a scoff than anything else, but a noise close to humour either way.

And somehow, *that’s* the most humiliating part of it all.

Phainon sinks into a chair in one of the more secluded areas, chucking the damning textbook and his bag onto the table with more force than necessary. A few loose sheets flutter dangerously close to the edge of falling off, and he has to snatch them up before they slip to the floor. *Focus*, he tells himself as he settles, taking his bulky laptop out of his bag and setting it on the table. He opens it, the welcome screen already waiting for him as he types in his password. His browser is still up, endless amounts of tabs loading in as the internet automatically connects to the library wifi. While it does that, he flips open his textbook, eyes skimming over dense paragraphs of text without absorbing a single word. He forces himself to slow down, taking a deep breath as he focuses back on the top of the page, but it's like his brain is coated in static. Nothing sticks. The numbers and theories blur together, meaningless.

Sharp cheekbones.

Phainon shakes his head, trying to reset. Hand hovering over his touchpad and the other rubbing the pages of his textbook together to soothe himself, he tries again. The words keep slipping through his brain like a sieve, and his mind keeps drifting back.

Amber eyes.

His grip turns punishing, almost ripping the paper, and his hand clatters against the keyboard, leaving a random group of letters in the search bar. Before he can clear it, his phone pings with a notification. Phainon fishes it

out of his jacket pocket, waiting for his Face ID to unlock it for him as it opens up directly into his text messages.

[9:09 pm] Castorice:

did u finish ur coursework yet

Phainon grimaces, scrolling back up their conversation, realising he hadn't replied to her previous text. She had sent him an encouraging message earlier in the day, full of exclamation points and aggressively supportive emojis, telling him *you got this* and that she believed in him. It'd made him smile at the time, but now he feels vaguely guilty for leaving her on read for so long.

[9:10 pm] Phainon:

no i'm dying

[9:10 pm] Castorice:

what did you do now

Phainon could cry. *Actually* cry. His eyes sting slightly as he blinks the dampness away, trying to shove down the overwhelming embarrassment that's clawing up his throat. A lump lodges itself there, thick and suffocating, making it even harder to swallow the reality of what just happened.

Never, in his entire existence, has he made an ass out of himself quite so spectacularly. And that's saying something, considering he's spent most of his life laughing off as much as possible and generally making a fool out of himself. But this? *This* is a new low. And the worst part is that it all happened in front of *him*. Not just some random stranger anymore, not just any unimportant passerby he'd never have to see again - but the librarian that'd been plaguing his thoughts. The same one he vowed to avoid, the same one he had lasted all of twenty hours staying away from before crashing headfirst into another humiliation.

In comparison, the first encounter wasn't bad at all. In fact, it was practically perfect.

[9:11 pm] Phainon:

so i met this guy lol

The sentence doesn't do it justice, but he isn't quite ready to fully delve into the situation through messages.

[9:11 pm] Castorice:

…go on

[9:12 pm] Phainon:

well

kinda

he’s the librarian on campus

[9:13 pm] Castorice:

just get on with it, i’m trying to watch a video essay on youtube

[9:13 pm] Phainon:

u texted me first!!!

anyway

he’s really pretty, like unreal levels

and i wanted to speak to him more so i went to return a textbook but it was actually mine lol

[9:15 pm] Castorice:

…

you tried returning ur own book???

Phainon groans, running his fingers through his hair before he continues the mortifying ordeal. He knew he should’ve kept this to himself, but the urge to tell his best friend everything sneaked up on him.

[9:16 pm] Phainon:

Yes.

[9:16 pm] Castorice:

lol i’m telling aglaea

[9:16 pm] Phainon:

DON’T

CAS PLEASE

[9:18 pm] Castorice:

already did hehe

she didn’t laugh but i could tell she wanted to

[9:19 pm] Phainon:

whyyyy 😭 i panicked

[9:20 pm] Castorice:

ur own fault for being dumb

Phainon scowls at his phone, fingers poised to type out a scathing response, when he’s stopped by a loud *shush* aimed towards him. He glances up,

meeting gazes with a student he’s never seen before.

“At least silence your phone if you’re going to keep texting.” The student hisses at him, going back to their laptop without giving Phainon a chance to respond.

He winces, flicking the silent button on the side of his phone. He decides he doesn’t want to reply to Castorice’s jeers anyway, she’d only continue to make fun of him for it. Phainon sinks into his chair, tucking his phone into his jacket pocket, head tilting back towards the ceiling as he takes in the panelling and the chandelier hanging above his head. He wants to let out a loud groan, but after already being told off for his phone pinging, he’d rather not risk disturbing anyone again. After all, he’s here for a reason, one that isn’t embarrassing himself in front of the front desk.

Phainon furrows his eyebrows, staring up at the ceiling like it holds the answers to all his academic struggles as if some divine revelation might descend upon him and miraculously sort out the mess that is his assignment. The lighting above flickers ominously, the old bulbs buzzing faintly, and yet the universe offers no more wisdom than that. He exhales slowly, letting his head drop forward again, rubbing a hand down his face as exhaustion creeps in. His shoulders feel stiff from being hunched over his laptop all day, despite moving around a lot to different study spots. There’s no time to stop now. His fingers tighten together, knuckles pressing against one another as he cracks them in quick succession - a small ritual, a desperate attempt of centering himself.

Three hours. Well, not even that as his laptop clock says it’s now 9:30 pm. That’s all he has left, 2 and a half measly hours to pull together something passable, to stitch his half-baked ideas into words that resemble a coherent

thought and a passing grade. He glances down at his notebook strewn next to his laptop - his writing is hurried, scattered and chaotic, full of frantic underlines and doodles. It’s an absolute mess.

He sighs again, planting his elbows on the table, fingers poised over the keyboard with a renewed determination. The clock is against him, and he’s still coming down from the most embarrassing moment of his life, but he’ll get this done *and* with time to spare, he bets.

Phainon isn’t sure what happens after he presses *Submit* on his final assessment, only that relief floods his system so heavily that it feels like he’s going to pass out. The next thing he knows, a voice is dragging him back to consciousness - steady, quiet, with just the faintest trace of exasperation.

“You shouldn’t sleep here.”

Phainon stirs, groggy and disoriented. His face is pressed against the open pages of his textbook, the words smudged from where his breath has warmed the paper. His limbs feel sluggish as he pushes himself upright, blinking against the desk lamp that feels all too bright now. It takes a second for his mind to catch up, to register the figure standing beside him.

Sharp features, warm amber eyes, posture straight and composed even in the late hours of the night.

The librarian.

Oh, no.

Embarrassment strikes like a slap to the face. He barely remembers falling asleep, only that he cheered quietly to himself when he saw the 100% completed next to his assignment, before flopping forward in exhaustion. Now that he's awake the weight of it - of *this* - settles over him like a thick blanket of shame. He's not even sure what's worse: the fact that he passed out in the middle of the library, or that *he* was the one to find him.

"I -" His voice cracks, hoarse from sleep. He clears his throat quickly, blinking rapidly and sitting up straighter. "I wasn't -" Phainon stops, realising mid-sentence that there's no point in denying it. He has no idea what time it is or how long he was out for, only that he's been caught red-handed. The evidence is probably all over his face, smudged ink and drool crusting at the edge of his lips. He groans softly, rubbing at his temple.

"Sorry about that."

The librarian - Phainon should really figure out his name, he's sick of not having one to put to his face at this point - of course, doesn't let him off easy by just leaving it there. He just tilts his head, gaze steady: "The library closes in ten minutes." He says, voice flat like they're not witnessing Phainon scrub at his lips to get rid of drool that'd leaked out during his nap. "You should start packing up."

Phainon chuckles humourlessly, dragging a hand through his tousled hair. “Yeah, will do.” He closes his laptop, flipping his textbook and notebook shut as he stacks everything in a pile ready to be put back into his bag.

Silence stretches between them for a moment, save for a distant creak of a floorboard somewhere deeper in the library. Phainon wonders if it’s just them now, the only two left inside. The air feels heavier than it should with that thought. The librarian hasn’t walked away yet, and his gaze is starting to make Phainon nervous, fidgeting in his seat as he shoves everything in his bag without any finesse. The zip jams as he tries to close it, getting caught on the spiral of his notebook sticking out. With a grumble, he pushes everything in as far as it can go.

“Falling asleep over your books isn’t exactly effective studying.”

Phainon jerks, head spinning to look up at the blonde man. He lets out a tired laugh, half genuine and half self-deprecating. “Yeah, well, straight A student here. So something must be working.”

For the first time, an emotion flickers in his expression. It’s small, barely there - a faint twitch at the corner of his lips, a ghost of a smirk. Not quite amused, his eyes still boring into Phainon without a trace of a spark, but close.

“Really?”

“*Really,*” Phainon emphasises, standing up and slinging his bag over his shoulder. He realises this is closer than they’ve ever been, and he blinks at the subtle height difference. He assumed the other was slightly taller, what with his bulkier build and the way he carried himself, but it turns out there’s a few inches difference in them. It’s not much - their eyes still meet without any trouble - but the thought sends butterflies tumbling through his stomach.

The librarian hums, cocking their head to the left as he takes Phainon in. His gaze moves slowly - deliberate, assessing. Phainon feels the weight of it as it drags over his face, pausing just long enough that his breath catches before it dips lower. Over the rumpled fabric of his t-shirt, across the way he haphazardly tucked it into the waistband of his jeans, the rips across his knees and thighs. His eyes flicker down even lower, down to his scuffed trainers, then just as unhurriedly, his gaze traces its way back up - lingering this time, as though piecing Phainon together from the inside out, as though trying to put together a puzzle.

Phainon shifts his weight onto his right leg. Is he a mess? Is he about to get kicked out, an official public nuisance for sleeping in the library? Finally, amber eyes meet his again, as unreadable as ever.

“Perhaps you’d be an A-*plus* student if you studied while awake.”

Phainon groans, shoulders slumping, whatever tension between them breaking. “Hey, don’t be mean! And that doesn’t exist, thankfully.”

The librarian raises an eyebrow, the faintest hint of amusement shaping his features. “Doesn’t exist?” He echoes, voice smooth, teasing. “Are you sure about that?”

Phainon crosses his arms, huffing dramatically. “Pretty sure if there *was* a higher grade, someone would’ve told me by now.”

A hum, “Or maybe no one bothered because they assumed you wouldn’t be aiming for it.”

Phainon gapes at him, affronted. What minor victory he had held at making the guy amused is sharply turning into wanting to rival this guy’s words. Phainon has already suffered enough around him at his own expense.

“Wow, *wow*. First you wake me up, then you insult my academic ambition? Harsh, much?”

The librarian scoffs, “If you had any real ambition, you wouldn’t have fallen asleep in the first place.”

Phainon scowls, but there’s no real bite to it. “Listen here, um -” He pauses, realising that he still doesn’t have a name. He peers down at the lanyard, enough so that he can finally make out a name. *Mydeimos Kremnos*.

The name tumbles from his lips all too easily. “*Mydeimos* -”

Mydeimos’s face curls up in disgust, eyes crinkling behind his glasses. “Just Mydei.”

“Okay, sure, cool, *just Mydei*,” Phainon says, trying not to laugh as Mydei’s expression sours even further. “Aren’t you supposed to encourage the students here or something?”

“Not part of my job,” Mydei replies tautly, “I’m here to keep students like you in check. Which -” Mydei brings up his arm, making a show of looking at his wristwatch. “You have 1 minute to leave before I lock you in here.”

“You wouldn’t!” Phainon gasps, genuinely startled by the fact that it’s almost midnight already. He must’ve slept for well over an hour then.

Mydei sneers, tilting his head down to look at Phainon over the rim of his glasses. “Don’t push me.”

“Fine, fine,” Phainon relents, walking past Mydei, making sure their shoulders brush against each other.

Mydei smells faintly of something sweet - subtle but distinct, lingering in the air between them. It’s not overpowering, nor artificial like some of the sickly perfumes people drown themselves in. No, this is softer, more natural, like a ripe fruit warmed by the sun. There’s a hint of tartness

beneath it, crisp and fresh, but the sweetness is what lingers the longest, curling about Phainon's senses like a hook he can't shake loose.

He wants to know *what* it is - whether it's cologne, or if it's Mydei's shampoo, or if it's just *him*. Phainon wants to lean in closer, to breathe deeper, to chase the scent until he can name it. But that would be insane. And obvious. And most definitely weird.

Still, it clings to him even after Mydei shifts away, the ghost of it teasing his senses as he exhales. As he wanders back through the shelves to the exit, Phainon swears it follows him, clinging to his jacket like it's haunting him in the best way possible.

Sunlight spills through the thin curtains, golden and insistent, creeping across the room until it lands directly on Phainon's face. He groans, shifting onto his side, dragging his duvet higher as if that will somehow shield him from the morning's intrusion. It doesn't. The warmth finds him anyway, seeping into his skin, and lighting up the backs of his eyelids in a soft, hazy glow.

He buries his face deeper into the pillow, sighing as the heat lulls him somewhere between wakefulness and sleep. For a brief moment, he lets himself sink into it - the quiet hum of the world outside his window, the faint rustle of leaves in the breeze, the way the sun kisses his cheeks, gentle and calming. It's *nice*. It's peaceful, and it almost makes him want to stay like this all day. He hasn't had the chance to wake up like this in who knows how long, his alarm ringing at stupid o'clock in the morning so he

can prepare for his morning lectures. Despite none of that, his body betrays him, a slow blink dragging him further into consciousness. His silver lashes stick together, his eyes dry and crusty with sleep. Phainon squints, groaning as he rubs at them half-heartedly.

It takes a second for reality to catch up to him, but when it does, the relief is instant. It's *Saturday*. No deadlines looming over his head anymore, no reason to race across campus in hopes of finding a place to study, and no early lectures to drag himself out of bed for. Just a whole day stretched out before him, open and unclaimed. A rare moment of freedom.

And yet, despite the absolute lack of obligations given to him in this current moment, he still feels a little restless. Phainon stares up at the ceiling, blinking sluggishly as the final remnants of sleep slip away. His body feels heavy, still tired, weighed down by the warmth of his duvet, yet his mind is already stirring, thoughts drifting aimlessly. He could stay in bed for a little longer - hell, he *should* stay in bed considering how early it is - but the energy coiling in his limbs won't let him.

With a deep sigh, he pushes himself upright, the sheets pooling around his waist as he runs a hand through his hair. It's a mess, sticking up in every direction, and when he catches his reflection in the mirror across the room, he grimaces. Not his best look, that's for sure. His eyelids are swollen, cheeks puffy and skin more pallid than usual with help from the dark circles under his eyes. The dorm room is quiet, the usual chaos of his comings and goings momentarily stilled.

Phainon grabs his phone from the nightstand, the screen lighting up the moment his fingers wrap around it. The glow of the screen feels too bright after just waking up, and he squints at it, blinking away the last blur of sleep

still clinging to his vision. The battery icon in the corner is fully charged, the cable loosely hanging from the bottom as he tugs it free and tosses it aside.

A cluster of notifications fills the screen - some from uni group chats, a few from his email, and one from an app reminding him about an assignment that, thankfully, he already submitted last night before passing out. At that, he cringes, shuddering before he can dwell on the memory of what occurred last night. He scrolls past it all, barely paying attention when a stack of messages from Castorice catches his eye. She'd sent it late last night after he'd already fallen asleep back in his dorm room. A quick tap opens their conversation, and he sees the string of texts: first, a gif of a cat aggressively typing, and then a dramatic '*you better be working on that paper and not ogling the hot librarian'* followed by an all-caps message 45 minutes later: '*PHAINON??? '*

Phainon huffs out a small laugh, shaking his head fondly as he types out a belated reply.

[7:13 am] Phainon:

sorry i was asleep, but i did finish my assignment

no ogling occurred

It was a lie, well, a white lie, at most. Mydei is *beautiful*, so much so that it was hard not to want to stand and stare. With his strong biceps flexing underneath the thin shirt as he moved, the cute braid in his hair, and his long legs wrapped in tight trousers. Anyway, he doesn't expect Castorice to reply this early considering it's the weekend, so he goes back to filtering

through the last of his notifications. More emails from the university, some from his professors with reminders about quizzes and practicals going on next week, a few random app alerts and one missed call from an unknown number that he immediately blocks. He goes through everything out of habit, making sure there are no red dots littering his home screen until he's got nothing left to distract him from the listlessness he feels.

Maybe he should do something productive and make the most of how many hours he has left in the day. He could finally organise his notes, get a head start on the group project that's coming up, or even clean his desk. Phainon glances over at it, motivation immediately dwindling when he sees how messy it is, covered in random sheets of paper and empty mugs. If he was to clean up, that'd mean sifting through each page individually, checking to make sure it was safe to throw out, and also braving the shared kitchen with his collection of mugs that need washing out. He groans, holding his head in his hands, letting his palms press against his eyes until colours begin to burst behind his lids. Phainon lets the tension leech out of his shoulders, flopping backwards to lie down again with a dramatic sigh.

This is *stupid*. Nothing seems to be worthy enough of his time, either too dull or too strenuous, causing his mind to drift, unbidden, to the library. He scowls at himself, *absolutely not*. He spent the past few days holed up in there, practically living amongst the bookshelves in a last-ditch attempt to get things done - which did technically work, but at what cost? He has enough embarrassment to fuel the rest of his life, and he'd rather not add anymore onto that, thanks. Yet, as his eyes close, determined to at least get another few hours of sleep, the image of amber eyes and soft lips flashes through his mind. His brow twitches in annoyance, scrunching his eyes tightly shut as if that'll help chase away the persistent thoughts.

It doesn't. It only makes them stronger, giving his brain free reign to run wild. Clarity sets in, slowly at first, and then descends all at once. He knows

what he’s going to do today, and although it may cost him more embarrassment, he’s going to do it anyway.

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading, if you enjoyed, please leave a comment!!! ヾ(≧▽≦*)o i need all the encouragement and love i can get to motivate me to finish writing this haha

-

let's be friends on twitter, i'm trying to use it more now :3 !

Chapter 2: chapter two

Chapter Summary

> “Well, what are *you* drinking then?”
>
> Mydei mutters something under his breath, but the words are swallowed up as he lifts his cup, the plastic lid partially obscuring his face. He takes a quick sip as if he’s trying to hide behind the drink itself.
>
> “Huh?” Phainon says dumbly, too caught up in his thoughts to process what Mydei had just said.
>
> “I *said*,” Mydei meets his eyes once again, skin slowly returning to its normal colour as he narrows his eyes almost accusingly at Phainon like he’s the one at fault here. “Pomegranate milk.”

Chapter Notes

> who's ready for more boyfailure phainon!! (everyone cheers)
>
> thank you to all the love i got on the first chapter, it made me so happy and motivated me to write this even faster ♪(^∇^*)
>
> unedited, so there will be mistakes.
>
> enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon goes back to the library.

He knows he shouldn’t, but he’s here anyway, already opening the heavy oak doors that welcome him back in with ease. With bated breath, he takes

a few steps inside, eyes fixed on the front desk. It takes a few moments for reality to set in, but when it does, it comes crashing down on him. Mydei isn't there, instead, a young guy with mint-coloured hair and an ominous-looking eyepatch is. Phainon freezes, eyes wide, completely taken off guard. His whole plan is ruined, just like that. He isn't even sure *what* his plan was, only that it involved seeing Mydei in some capacity.

The eyepatch librarian spots him loitering by the door, "Do you need help?"

"Ah! Uh, no," Phainon laughs nervously and quickly runs off towards an empty table.

The library is nearly silent at this hour, save for the quiet hum of the heating vents and the occasional rustle of someone flipping a page. Only a handful of students are here, scattered throughout the space, already buried in their work, heads bowed over their laptops and notebooks. Their quiet focus makes Phainon feel like an intruder in the space, his lack of purpose glaring in contrast.

With a sigh, he drops into a chair, letting his bag thud onto the table beside him. At least he had the foresight to bring his study materials and didn't turn up here empty-handed; that would've made this whole fiasco a hundred times worse. He unzips his bag and starts pulling things out: laptop, notebook, a pencil case that'd seen better days, and spreads them across the table in an attempt to look like he belongs here.

Flipping aimlessly through his notes, he skims over equations and half-legible scribbles, yet none of it sticks. He goes to his laptop instead,

refreshing his email, more out of an anxious tick than any real expectation of something new. Of course, there's nothing, still empty from earlier on when he cleared everything out. There's truly nothing to distract him, just an empty inbox and an even emptier to-do list.

Technically, he *could* start researching for the upcoming pop quiz. He could get ahead and do something productive with this stretch of time he's found himself occupying. But the idea of spending his weekend buried in coursework makes his stomach twist unpleasantly. Phainon's already spent the entire week chasing deadlines, barely catching his breath between lectures and labs. Instead, he's here, wasting his Saturday morning sitting in the library with nowhere else to be, nothing else to do, and the restless feeling that he's just waiting for something to happen. The space in the library feels empty, the silence heavier than usual. It feels… different, like something is missing. It's not hard for his brain to make the connection: what's missing is *Mydei*.

After a few minutes of sulking, he's brought out of his reverie when he hears voices near the entryway. His ears perk up, heart skipping a beat, hopeful for a certain someone to have just walked in, but his hopes are quickly dashed when he sees it's just a student asking eyepatch guy a question. An idea forms in his head then - *he* can go ask the guy a question, too.

He waltzes up to the front desk after the other student leaves, leaving him face-to-face with the current librarian. He's dressed strangely like he's cosplaying someone straight out of the Victorian era. The guy flicks one uninterested eye up at him as he approaches.

“So, um…” Phainon hesitates. The words are right there, on the tip of his tongue: *Is Mydei working today?* But suddenly, they feel wrong. What if that’s too invasive? What if the eyepatch guy sees right through him and ends up telling Mydei about some weird student asking after him?

Eyepatch librarian taps a finger on the desk, irritated. “Yes?”

“Is the library open late today?” Phainon asks, the question tumbling out.

There’s a pause. A raised eyebrow. Then, “We close at midnight. Same as always.”

“Right, yeah, of course. Just checking.” Phainon nods stiffly, and before he can think better of it, he continues: “Are you the only librarian working today?” That should be vague enough, right? He didn’t mention anyone specific, at least.

The librarian gives him a weird look - *shit, he’s fucked up* - his single eye narrowed in on Phainon, far too assessing than what’s comfortable. “If there’s anything I can help you with, I’m more than capable.” He says in a flat, cool tone.

Oh, ouch, the guy took it the wrong way.

“No - I, um, didn’t mean it like that. It’s fine, I was just curious.” Phainon grimaces and turns around to leave, but turns back to face the eyepatch guy. “Anyway, thanks, bye.” He finishes, scurrying back to his table without waiting for a response.

After the non-answer he got from the eyepatch librarian earlier, Phainon sticks around for another 30 minutes. Every sound, every shift in movement, every breath, he’s aware, constantly checking the entryway to see if Mydei’s miraculously walked in while he wasn’t looking. It doesn’t happen, and by the time the clock ticks into mid-morning, he’s fed up. Tired and hungry, downtrodden and defeated, Phainon decides he’s going to use the last remaining credits in his bank account to buy himself the most sickly sweet hot chocolate he can afford to cheer himself up.

The journey to the cafe doesn’t take long, and within 20 minutes he’s arrived, listening to the chime of the bell above his head as he enters. The atmosphere inside is polar opposite to that of the library. Everything feels so *alive*, buzzing with people chatting and the hiss of the espresso machine. The interior is all light wood and modern, with fairy lights draping around the walls to create a softer vibe. He feels instantly welcomed and sheds the remainder of his upset as he walks up to the counter, eyes hungrily scouring across the baked goods. Maybe he can spare a few credits in his overdraft to get one, and with that thought, he orders a brownie and a hot chocolate, making sure to emphasise that he wants extra marshmallows and whipped cream.

Order in hand, he finds a spare table by the window, allowing him a clear view of the outside. It’s considerably gloomier than it had been when he woke up, the sun hiding behind the clouds, but he thinks nothing more of it

as he tucks into his food. The brownie is dense and fudgy, just the way he likes as he licks over his teeth to unstick it. Usually, the smell of coffee and cinnamon would lift his spirits, or revitalise him through some form of osmosis or whatever. But today that doesn't seem to be the case, even as he polishes off the rest of his food.

Phainon probably should've just stayed at home, bit the bullet and braved the shared kitchen. It was early enough at the time that no one would be in there, devoid of his dorm mates who were all out partying last night. At least he gets to have this now, a peaceful moment to savour sweet treats. He takes the first sip of his hot chocolate. That, too, is nice and thick, with a creamy aftertaste that leaves him immediately wanting more before he's finished the first gulp. He smiles to himself, shoulders beginning to relax as he finally settles.

It's not *all* bad, he reasons, grabbing his phone from out of his pocket to fiddle around with. There are still no emails to catch up with, so he loses himself playing a silly cat game and scrolling through the many uni group chats he's a part of. He doesn't say much in them, throwing out an occasional gif and reacting to other people's messages, but he does laugh at a few memes and dramatic distress texts coming through. His department is so big, with so many divisions, that it's hard to keep track of everyone. Phainon wishes Castorice was with him, or even Aglaea who was somewhat of an overseer of them all during secondary school. Even if they attended the same university, they'd all be in different departments with their own schedules, but at least he'd be able to share a coffee with them more often than not.

With that, he absorbs himself into the cat game, alternating between matching pairs of cats together to taking sips of his hot chocolate. The only thing that startles him out of his focus is when the door swings open, bringing a cold gust of air with it. The bell jingles, alerting everyone to the

newcomer. It'd rung a few times since Phainon had arrived, but this one caught his attention for some reason. A magnet pull is ushering him to look up, and so he does, glancing up over the edge of his almost-finished hot chocolate. When he finds out who just came in, he almost chokes on his drink.

It's *Mydei*, looking slightly out of place in the bright tones of the cafe, dressed in an all-black ensemble: a cropped leather jacket, a loose band tee and a pair of tight jeans, finished off with a well-worn pair of Converses. He looks so different under the cafe lighting, his blonde hair radiant, his posture untouchable as he walks up to the counter to order.

Phainon knows he's staring, probably looking as though he's seen a ghost. He swallows his hot chocolate down like a mouthful of nails and shakily sets his mug down on the saucer, the sound of clattering china too loud in his ears above the whooshing of his pulse. Mydei's back is towards him, his arm reaching up to point to something on the blackboard above the server, and Phainon allows him the brief moment of privacy to *look*.

Mydei's shoulders are broad, emphasised by the tapered cut of his slim waist that makes Phainon's mouth water. He shouldn't allow his eyes to drift any lower, they should only stay above board, watching the way Mydei's muscles shift even beneath his jacket, all power and sureness, but he can't help himself. The pull is too much, the desire overpowering and his eyes move lower, past the hem of the cropped jacket, past the waist of his jeans and *lower*, until his gaze is fully on Mydei's ass. His jaw snaps shut with an audible clack of his teeth, eyes immediately veering off course as his cheeks redden. The jeans do nothing for his thighs, but *everything* for his ass, clearly. A seed of knowledge he will now have to live with, which he's not sure if he loves or hates.

Flushed up to his ears, he sinks down in the chair, eyes now at a more appropriate level as he watches Mydei turn around, a take-out cup in hand and his wallet in the other. Like two puzzle pieces slotting together, their eyes meet. Mydei's eyebrows lift, and *shit*, that can only mean one thing: he recognises Phainon. In a sheer panic, Phainon breaks the connection and pretends to look back at his phone, staring wide-eyed at his lockscreen.

"Is this seat taken?"

Phainon's heart skitters in his chest, his stomach clenching and unclenching as he glances up. Mydei is there, standing beside his table, honeyed eyes flicking between him and the half-empty mug in front of him. Phainon sits up straight, clearing his throat quickly. He wasn't expecting Mydei to even notice him, let alone come over and talk. He's completely taken off guard, first by his sudden appearance and now this. He discreetly glances around the cafe, noticing that it's filled up considerably since he arrived.

"Nope, it's free."

In awe, he watches as Mydei draws back the chair and sits down opposite him, placing his wallet and cup on the table without a preamble. The immediate silence between them is so stifling that Phainon feels a little choked by it. He scrambles to think of anything to say - *hey, I missed you at the library today,* or *where were you*? But neither option is a good one, and he'd like to not come across like a clingy puppy where he can.

"Hot chocolate?" Mydei asks flatly, cutting the silence in half.

Phainon bristles, curling his fingers almost protectively around his mug. “Yeah, and?” He sniffs, wondering whether he should be offended or not. He still can’t get a clear read on Mydei, whether it’s from his lack of expressions and neutral tone, it’s hard to get a feel for the guy. It makes him want to try harder, to push a few more buttons and see what the outcome would be.

“I thought straight-A students like you ran on nothing but triple-shot espressos.”

Phainon gapes at him for a split second before laughing. “Sure, if I was desperate for an early grave, that is.”

“And filling your body with sugar isn’t doing the same?” Mydei questions.

“Don’t tell me you’re some kind of health nut…” Phainon replies.

Mydei reclines back in his chair, shaking his head slightly. It impresses Phainon how much space Mydei takes up - not just physically, although that alone is undeniable to his chagrin, but in the sheer vastness of his presence alone. Even when he’s standing still, like when he was ordering at the counter, there’s something about him that draws the eye, magnetic and enticing in the way he holds himself. And now, sitting down, his legs spread wide, as though he’s a king lounging on a throne and not on a rickety wooden chair, and Phainon can hardly even imagine not admiring him.

On the other hand, he has to chant *don't look, don't look, don't look* in his head, eyes practically straining to remain at eye level and not down to where Mydei's thighs are deliciously spread open. He clears his throat, pointedly taking a big gulp of his now lukewarm hot chocolate.

"Well, what are *you* drinking then?"

Mydei pauses, and for the first time, Phainon sees something unfamiliar flicker across his face: *hesitance*. It's subtle, barely there at first, but then it begins to transform in a way that Phainon isn't prepared for. Gone is the unwavering confidence and the cool indifference, slowly unspooling like a loose ball of yarn into something else, something softer, something more vulnerable. Like the first blush of dawn creeping over the horizon, colour rises to Mydei's cheeks. A soft, rosy hue dusts across his sharp cheekbones, delicate and yet undeniably there. It spreads slowly as a drop of ink in water would, sprawling up to the tips of his ears, his body betraying a secret he refuses to speak aloud. Phainon watches, captivated, as the warmth settles into his skin, staining it.

He wishes he could take a picture. His fingers itch to grab his phone and open the camera app and snap a few for his own safekeeping. Phainon's never seen anything like this before, this beautiful, this breathtaking. Mydei's amber eyes dart away, suddenly unable to meet his gaze. His lips press together briefly, only to part the next second, as if he's struggling to hold something back. It's a far cry from the cutting remarks and quiet arrogance Phainon has come to expect of him, and he can't decide which one he prefers. Maybe both, maybe neither.

Mydei mutters something under his breath, but the words are swallowed up as he lifts his cup, the plastic lid partially obscuring his face. He takes a

quick sip as if he’s trying to hide behind the drink itself.

“Huh?” Phainon says dumbly, too caught up in his thoughts to process what Mydei had just said.

“I *said*,” Mydei meets his eyes once again, skin slowly returning to its normal colour as he narrows his eyes almost accusingly at Phainon like he’s the one at fault here. “Pomegranate milk.”

“P-pomegranate milk?” Phainon repeats, blinking rapidly as he processes the information. “They make that here?” Is the first question out of his mouth, but he has a plethora more building up.

Mydei scowls, and there he is, completely back to his usual gruff self. “Why wouldn’t they?”

“Why *would* they? Who even orders that?” Phainon pauses, gesturing towards Mydei. “Well, except for you, obviously. I didn’t even know pomegranate syrup existed.”

“Do you have a problem with my drink?” Mydei replies through gritted teeth, a threat more than a question.

Phainon raises his hands in surrender. “Hey, no more than whatever you have against my hot chocolate.”

Mydei scoffs, rolling his eyes.

There’s a tense pause between them, both of them stuck at an impasse. It lingers, hovering between them like an unsteady bridge neither of them want to risk crossing. As Mydei’s gaze turns downward once more, Phainon exhales slowly, realising with a flicker of embarrassment that at some point during the last few minutes he’d leaned forward, drawn into Mydei without thinking, like an unruly dog straining against its leash.

He forces himself to sit back, his spine loosening as he picks up his mug again to give his hands something to do. The shift feels like a retreat, a quiet surrender to the ever-present push and pull that exists between them. Mydei doesn’t move and doesn’t say anything, either, so neither does Phainon, tipping the rest of his drink into his mouth to finish off in one go. The sweetness of the hot chocolate sticks to his tongue like the sweetness of Mydei’s blush, cloying and addicting. He doesn’t expect there to be any more conversation passed between them - if it could even be called that. It was more of a collision, two forces meeting head-on and scattering in opposite directions, never able to meet in the middle.

It seems that regardless of the setting - whether they’re in the library, the cafe, or anywhere else in between, they’re destined to exist in this constant state of friction, rubbing together like sandpaper, and forced away like opposing magnets. It makes Phainon want to keep pushing, to keep pressing closer and closer until the tension between them snaps and he can break through to the other side.

Phainon wants so much, probably too much considering how little they know each other, yet he's nothing but determined when he puts his mind to something. He wants to reach out, tug at Mydei's braid to see him flinch, to see if that'll make him blush so prettily again. He wants to grab the paper cup clutched between his hands and try the pomegranate milk himself, to see if it tastes as sweet as Mydei smells. He wants words instead of silence and wants to understand why, despite the way they clash, he can't seem to stay away.

Mydei sighs, the sound quiet and unsure. "That came out all wrong."

Phainon startles, "So you admit you started it?"

After another roll of his eyes, Mydei's arms crossed over his chest, unimpressed. "I didn't *start* anything, I was trying to make conversation."

Phainon shrugs, "You could've just asked me about the weather."

"Fine, then." Mydei tosses a careless glance outside the window. "It looks like it's going to rain."

"What?!" Phainon follows his gaze outside, eyes widening when he realises Mydei's right. "Shit, I didn't bring an umbrella."

Mydei smirks, "I did."

Phainon whips his head back around to face the librarian. He glares, bottom lip jutting out into a pout as Mydei stands up, chair scraping against the linoleum floor.

“You better get a move on, it’s already starting to come down.”

Phainon makes a garbled noise and quickly grabs his bag from the back of his chair and slips it over his shoulder, trailing after Mydei as they weave around tables and patrons.

“Hey, wait up, Mydei!” Phainon yells as the other opens the door, letting it shut in his face before he has a chance to grab the handle.

Phainon grumbles, mood turning sour as he flings the door open to catch up. He skids to a stop before he can get any further, stuck underneath the awning, watching despondently as Mydei takes a few steps into the rain with his umbrella open above him.

“No fair! Where did you even pull that out from?” Phainon asks, grousing.

Mydei glances over his shoulder, eyes distant behind his glasses. He shrugs, “Better run back home if you want to make it.” He lifts a hand and waves goodbye without even a second glance at Phainon, leaving him stranded at the cafe entrance.

“You bastard,” He grits out, scowling so much that his forehead aches with how much he’s furrowing his brows. He didn’t say it loud enough to be heard, but as he watches Mydei’s retreating back shaking slightly with what he assumes is laughter, he guesses he heard it anyway.

“*Bastard*,” Phainon repeats with more feeling, making sure to keep it under his breath this time.

He waits a few minutes, glancing between the downpour and the direction of his dorm building. It’s not like he can go back inside and sit down, his table is already taken and he doesn’t have any more money to spend on expensive drinks and food. His only option is to brave it and run back, and as he puts his bag over his head to try and shield him from the rain, he makes a break for it.

Phainon stumbles into his dorm, the door clicking shut behind him as he breathes out a sigh of relief at finally being inside. Rain drips from his hair, trailing cold rivulets down the nape of his neck and soaking into the already wet collar of his shirt. He toes off his trainers at the door, grimacing at the squelching sound they make, water seeping out from them and onto the floor to create a little puddle. His socks are equally as soaked, clinging uncomfortably to his feet as he peels them off and tosses them to the side to be dealt with later.

His t-shirt is next, damp and heavy against his skin as he pulls it up and over his head. It lands with a sodden *slap* against the floor, and he barely suppresses a shiver as cool air rushes over his newly exposed skin. Goosebumps ripple across his entire body as his jeans follow next, sticking stubbornly to his legs as they tangle between his knees before finally sliding down and off. Now, standing in nothing but his damp boxers, Phainon shudders, arms wrapping around himself as the chill seeps into his bones. He's not far off from his teeth chattering, so with quick efficiency he runs into his ensuite and turns the shower on, making sure it's on the hottest setting before he sets off on the hunt for a towel and clean, dry clothes.

After he's done showering, he flops down on his unmade bed, not caring that his hair is still wet and dripping all over his pillow. He'd towel-dried it as soon as he came out of the shower, but the water had gathered again at the tips of his hair, droplets of water slipping off. He grabs his phone, dialling Castorice's number before he can think any better of it. Phainon taps the screen so it's on loudspeaker and dumps the phone next to his head, making sure it's just out of reach of the wet spot he created. Castorice picks up on the third ring.

"Hel -"

"Cas, the hot librarian is a *jerk*."

"Wow, hi to you too, Phainon. My day's going just fine, thank you for asking."

Phainon huffs a laugh, the familiar wash of her voice comforting him instantly more than a warm shower ever could. It’s been so long since they’d spoken like this, and his heart aches with the distance between them.

“He left me alone in the rain while he walked off with an umbrella!”

“Well, was it *his* umbrella?”

“It was,” Phainon clicks his tongue in annoyance, blowing a stray piece of hair out the way that's gotten caught in his eyelashes. “But still…”

“Then he had every right to,” Castorice replies, the sound of her nails flying across her keyboard in the background.

Phainon whines, shuffling onto his side so he can press his cheek into his pillow. “C’mon, Cas, you’re supposed to be on my side here.”

“Absolutely not,” Castorice snips back, and then she sighs, the typing sound stopping. “I’m assuming there’s more to this story?”

Phainon brightens up immediately and launches into a detailed retelling of his day, starting right from when he woke up to the moment he got back to his dorm.

“So let me get this straight,” Castorice begins slowly, clearly still digesting the amount of information that’s been dumped on her in a single sitting. “You went to the library hoping to see him, got all sad when you didn’t, and then somehow accidentally bumped into him at the campus cafe?”

Phainon huffs, “Well, when you put it like that, it sounds weird.”

“Because it is! Why did you go to the library when you had no plan and no work to do?” She chastises, voice raising slightly from its usual quiet tone. “Did you at least act like a normal human being this time or did you make a fool out of yourself?”

“You have no faith in me at all,” Phainon says. “I was fine, like I said, he’s the one who started it by insulting my drink of choice.”

A beat of silence, and then Castorice snorts. “What did you order?”

“Hot chocolate.”

The laugh that bursts through the speaker is enough to make Phainon flinch and edge away from his phone.

“Oh, gods, no wonder he judged you. What kind of engineering student still drinks hot chocolate?”

“So much for moral support!” Phainon grumbles. “He made fun of my drink, but turns out he was drinking pomegranate milk the entire time.”

“So you’re both weirdos, got it.”

“What does everyone have against hot chocolate all of a sudden? Adults can enjoy it too, y’know!”

“Look, I support your right to embarrass yourself. Always and forever. But you were literally drinking *chocolate milk*, so is there really a difference between the two?”

Phainon blinks, completely stumped by that.

At his confirming silence, Castorice hums. “Exactly. Now, is there anything else or can I go back to my essay?”

“Don’t go yet,” Phainon panics, grabbing his phone and turning it off loudspeaker. He presses it to his ear, “How have you been?”

“Oh, now he cares,” Castorice says sarcastically. “Finally had enough of talking about your crush?”

Phainon sputters, cheeks heating. “I don’t have a crush on him!”

“You’ve just spent the past hour talking my ear off about how hot and pretty he is, how much of a dickhead he is, how much you want to see him that you keep going out of your way to do so… And you don’t think you have a crush? Or even like him a tiny bit?”

“I barely know him!”

“But you *want* to know him.”

Phainon sits with that thought for a long moment, staring blankly at his wall. *Does* he want to get Mydei like that? It’s not as though their past encounters have gone particularly well. In fact, most of them have been nothing short of a disaster - awkward, embarrassing, filled with moments he wishes he could erase from existence. At best, they’ve been tolerable, moments of begrudging civility as they chatted. At worst, though? Life-altering and *humiliating*.

And yet, despite it all, there’s something about Mydei that keeps pulling him back in, wanting more and more. Phainon pictures him flushed and hiding behind his take-out cup, muttering about pomegranate milk. He wants *that* - more of his shyness, more of his crass words, even his sneers and the way he’s so full of softness and sharp edges. Maybe it’s the way he carries himself, poised and unapproachable like he knows exactly who he is and what he wants. Or maybe it’s the way he looks at Phainon through those glasses of his, direct and unafraid. Whatever it is, it leaves Phainon

feeling exposed, as though Mydei can see right through him and pick out every flaw that he's not even aware of.

Their interactions are more like battles, that's for sure. Mydei is reserved and precise while Phainon is a hurricane of emotions, all instinct and impulse. Every conversation they've had feels like a test, one he's constantly failing, and he's not used to that. He's used to coming out on top: top of his class, top of his grade, triumphing amongst others. It drives him crazy because the more they talk, the less he understands the other, but the more he wants to get closer - to piece together how a man he once mistook as a security guard ends up becoming a librarian. And yet, every time he opens his mouth, he somehow manages to widen the distance between them instead.

It shouldn't matter. He should just write Mydei off as a lost cause, cut his losses early and back off before he can get even more entrapped in Mydei's allure. But the problem is, against all his instincts and pride, it *does* matter to him. He so, *so* desperately wants Mydei to like him.

"Oh." Is all Phainon says.

"Yeah, *oh*, now I'm going to finish my essay and leave you to ruminate in peace. Goodbye."

Before he can react, Castorice has already hung up. Phainon lies down on his back and drops his phone onto his chest with a soft *thud*, breathing out slowly to try and calm his racing heart.

He *likes* Mydei.

The realisation settles in like a weight pressing down on his ribs. It’s not that shocking, really, now that he thinks about it more deeply. He’s been rhapsodising about how attractive Mydei is for days, ever since they first met, but now that he’s admitted it to himself and Castorice by extension, it feels as though there’s no point of return.

He stares at his ceiling, trapped in thought. Without anyone to talk to, his room is eerily quiet apart from the soft hum of the rain against his window, rhythmic and steady. It should be soothing, he even sometimes listens to rain sounds to help him get to sleep, but his mind refuses to slow down for even a second. Phainon considers texting Castorice to take it all back, to pretend that he’s just being over dramatic due to stress, but he knows she’d see right through him. Plus, he doesn’t want to disturb her any more than he already has.

Phainon lets his eyes drift shut, images of warm amber eyes and pretty pink cheeks lulling him to sleep.

The next few weeks blur together. The weather turns awful: heavy rain, strong winds and record-low temperatures. It makes travelling anywhere but the main building and his dorm room miserable, so much so that he avoids going anywhere else. He stays inside as much as he can, huddled in his room and working until he can’t keep his eyes open anymore, trying (and failing) not to think about Mydei. It helps that his lectures pick back

up, drowning him in enough work to keep him occupied from frivolous thoughts.

Before he knew it, almost a month had passed since he last saw Mydei.

Phainon feels the absence more than he should. He tells himself it’s fine, that it’s normal to go this long without seeing someone he barely knows. But after waking up from countless dreams about mysterious red tattoos, amber eyes and soft blonde hair, he has to admit that it’s getting a bit much. The restlessness under his skin won’t go away, turning into an itch he can’t scratch, even with how much he distracts himself between studying and hanging out with his classmates.

One evening, he gets a text.

[5:07 pm] Castorice:

that’s it i’ve had enough

you’ve been acting weird since we last spoke on the phone

[5:08 pm] Phainon:

wdym

[5:08 pm] Castorice:

don't be dense.

you’re pining

[5:11 pm] Phainon:

no i’m not

[5:11 pm] Castorice:

you haven’t seen your librarian since the cafe incident, have u?

[5:12 pm] Phainon:

first of all, he isn’t my anything

second of all, no i havent. bc i’ve been busy

[5:12 pm] Castorice:

:/

go and visit him, you sap

ur making me miserable

so go do something about it

Phainon sighs, locking his phone and chucking it behind him, listening to it bounce on his bed before he goes back to his essay. He doesn’t reply.

But it doesn’t mean he doesn’t *think* about it. Castorice’s words plague him just as much as Mydei does, gnawing at him until he feels full of holes.

He’s stretched thin, agonising over deadlines and his workload, until it all explodes on Wednesday, a week since Castorice last texted him.

[2:03 pm] Castorice:

if you don’t go and see him right now i’ll get on a train, wasting an extortionate amount of money, and drag you to that damned library myself

[2:04 pm] Phainon:

…

fine, i’ll go.

has anyone told u ur scary when you’re mad?

Phainon steps into the library, shivering as he shakes off the lingering cold from his coat. It’s still not particularly nice outside, but it’s stopped raining at least, which he counts as a small win. The heady scent of books and polished wood greets him like an old friend, and he supposes he’s missed this, too. He exhales slowly, heart thudding just a little too fast to consider

normal. On instinct, his eyes begin moving, gaze sweeping across the room, searching.

And there he is.

Mydei sits behind the front desk, a single beam of light coming through one of the upper floor's windows, bathing him in an ethereal light as he leans over a book in front of him. He's not reading it, though, instead writing something in the margins with a sleek black pen. His movements are slow and deliberate as he looks between his computer screen and the book. There's a faint crease between his eyebrows, his lips pressed together in quiet concentration. The sight of him - *this* version of him, so utterly focused and so at ease in this quiet pocket of time - makes Phainon's stomach flip.

Phainon's not sure what he expected when he turned up here, but now he loathes to disturb him. He'd subconsciously already come to terms with the idea that Mydei might not even be here at all, that fate and bad timing would keep them apart for another day. Or maybe he'd already come to terms with the fact that Mydei would be here, but wouldn't look quite so striking in the sunlight, so unfairly dedicated to his work and effortlessly beautiful in a way that makes Phainon's throat dry. It's stupid, it's an overreaction, but even as Phainon swallows down all these roiling feelings bubbling inside of him, he can't quite seem to find it in him to move. It's been so long, almost an entire month since the cafe incident, which left him soaked and thoroughly unamused at Mydei abandoning him, but it's all washed away in the gentle scratching of pen against paper and the occasional clicking of a mouse. Phainon feels even more off-balance than before he arrived here, like something is teetering on the edge of his ribs, threatening to tumble out.

He could go up to him and strike up a conversation. Yet that'd mean breaking the quiet atmosphere surrounding him. Phainon hesitates, fingers clenching and unclenching around his bag strap, pulse thundering in his ears. The way Mydei sits in his worn leather chair, spine slightly hunched over, head going back and forth between the book and his computer, makes Phainon feel as unwelcome as an intruder breaking into a moment that isn't his to begin with. He sighs, ready to write the day off as another lost cause, holding onto the fact that he'd at least gotten to *see* Mydei which is more than he's done in the past few weeks, but before he gets a chance to leave, Mydei glances up.

For a second - a split second, nothing more - neither of them move. Mydei's hand stops writing and golden eyes flicker over him, searching, expression unreadable. Then, as quickly as it happened, Mydei looks away, back down at his book as though Phainon is nothing more than a passing figure in the background. That should be the end of the moment, he should take the hint and back out while he can. Phainon has gotten what he wanted, after all: to see Mydei. It didn't lead to much, and he should understand that Mydei is busy enough to not even acknowledge him with a *hello*, but his feet are already moving.

With each step, his stomach twists up into knots. A hundred half-formed thoughts race through his mind. Does he say *hi*? Does he make up an excuse as to why he's here - such as needing to use the printer or maybe needing extra resources? Does he crack a joke about how Mydei left him for dead in the rain and how he got absolutely soaked, or would that make Mydei look at him like he's some kind of disaster again?

By the time he reaches the front desk, his thoughts are still in shambles, and he's no closer to an answer than before.

Phainon clears his throat. Mydei doesn’t look up.

“Hey,” Phainon says, voice breaking. He flushes, eyes widening as he clears his throat a few more times. He hasn’t had any issues with his voice cracking since he was a *teenager*, but of course, it had to happen right now.

Mydei finally lifts his gaze at that, one brow rising in silent acknowledgement. He doesn’t look particularly surprised to see him after the long break between them, nor does he seem particularly interested, and that - for some reason - irks Phainon more than it should.

“I see you didn’t drown in the rain then,” Mydei says flatly.

Phainon forces a grin, the muscles in his cheeks twinging with the stretch. He leans an elbow on the front desk as casually as he can, but Mydei immediately glares pointedly at it, and he withdraws the motion as quickly as it comes.

“No thanks to you,” Phainon replies, definitely still not slightly miffed about the umbrella incident. “But turns out I need to study, so here I am.”

Mydei sits back in his chair, the worn leather creaking with the motion. “Here you are, indeed.” he hums, eyes scanning Phainon in that slow, measured way that makes his skin heat.

He’s grateful he dressed better this time: a crisp white shirt tucked into black slacks, topped with a thick woollen coat and a dark blue scarf that Castorice knitted him wrapped around his neck. It’s completely overboard, and as he stared at the reflection in the mirror before he left for the library, he felt like a little kid dressed in his dad’s suit. Now, it all seems worth it, basking in the lingering way Mydei watches him.

“I thought you’d given up by now since I haven’t seen you in a while,” Mydei remarks.

Phainon’s eyebrows furrow, “Given up at what, studying?” A beat. A blink. A fluttering of his traitorous heart. Then: “Wait, you noticed I’ve been gone?”

Mydei’s face instantly twists into a half-formed snarl, but even that can’t disguise the way his cheeks are slightly pink. “Hardly.” He looks away, staring down at the book open in front of him. “Considering how easily you get distracted, I was right to assume.”

It’s a simple statement, but it stirs something deep within Phainon, like a challenge. “I do not get easily distracted.”

Mydei peers up at him above his glasses, his eyes shining in the sunlight and so, so warm. “You were staring at me with your mouth wide open for a full thirty seconds before you walked over.”

“That’s not -!” Phainon splutters, his own face heating from being called out. “I was -”

“*Distracted*, exactly,” Mydei cuts him off, a satisfied smirk lazing across his lips. He looks like a cat, sprawled out across his chair, basking in the sunlight, silently pleased with himself.

“Because of *you*,” Phainon huffs.

“Me?” Mydei repeats incredulously.

“Yeah, ‘cause you’re like…” Phainon gestures vaguely towards Mydei as if that’ll finish his sentence for him. It doesn’t. “Y’know…”

“I don’t know,” Mydei replies, pushing his glasses up his nose.

Phainon’s shoulders curve inwards, a groan escaping his mouth. “You’re really gonna make me say it?”

“I don’t even know what *it* is. Are you going to continue wasting my time, or do you need something?” Mydei says, focusing his attention elsewhere, looking at his computer as he shakes the mouse to wake the screen back up again.

“Because you’re *beautiful*.”

Mydei freezes, hands immediately stopping in their tracks before he can type anything, wide eyes flickering back up to Phainon. Phainon’s face is ablaze, sweat pin-pricking at his temples and upper lip. Why, *why* did he admit that?! Mydei is probably going to kick him out now, report him to the dean for harassment, get him banned from entering the library until he graduates, or -

“Since you seem so adamant about embarrassing yourself in front of me,” Mydei begins, startling Phainon out of his spiralling thoughts. “Here.”

He watches as Mydei tears off a post-it note with a decisive *rip*, scribbling something down on it before he shoves it at Phainon. He hesitates, acting like a deer caught in headlights with his face burning in shame, and doesn’t move. Mydei grumbles, waving the post-it note around a bit, urging him to grab it. Phainon finally does, his limbs unfreezing just enough to snatch it away, accidentally crumpling it in his hand.

He gulps, looking down at it.

07-XXXX-XXXXX

“Your number?” Phainon says hollowly, head completely empty for once, eyes going from the black ink on yellow paper to Mydei’s blank face.

“Yes,” Mydei confirms, going back to his book once again, fingers wrapping tightly around his pen. It’s a dismissal if he’s ever seen one, but he still has so many questions. “Now go focus on your work, which is why you came here in the first place.”

No, Phainon wants to fall to his knees and howl like a dog. *I came here to see you*. Well, it’s like, 60 - no, 80% of the reason why he came here. The majority is because of Mydei, but he did bring his laptop and textbooks with him. With nothing left to say, Phainon nods dumbly in goodbye and wanders over to a nearby table, forgoing his usual one in the corner for a clear view of Mydei. The reality of the situation is slowly setting in as he unpacks his bag. First, his laptop. *Mydei gave me his number*. Next, his textbook and notepad. *Mydei gave me his number without even having to ask.* Lastly, his pencil case. *Mydei gave me his number, without even having to ask, and now I can text him.*

With everything spread out across the table, he risks a glance at the front desk. It’s a bit awkward, with a bookshelf half in the way, but if he subtly leans over to the left, he can get a pretty clear look at Mydei’s face, which is all he needs.

Phainon quickly grabs his phone, typing the number into his contacts, double and triple checking that it’s correct. He stalls when he arrives at needing to name it. He begins typing:

Mydei (Librarian)

But that feels too cold, too professional. He backspaces.

Mydeimos

Is that too personal? Mydei had made it clear how little he enjoyed his full name when he first called him it. He deletes everything again, the empty text bar flashing at him ominously.

Mydei

Simple and easy. Phainon’s thumb hovers over the confirm button.

Mydei

He grins to himself, that’s better. The strawberry emoji isn’t quite right, either, but since there’s no pomegranate one, it’ll have to do. It’s red and sweet, so practically the same thing, right? Phainon huffs a laugh at his reasoning and locks his phone, putting it screen down on the table. He taps his finger against the wood, chin in his palm as he idly watches Mydei from afar. All his stuff is out and ready to be used, but instead he grabs his phone again, opening up a new text conversation.

[2:23 pm] Phainon:

hey, it’s phainon

wait idk if you even know my name

guy with silver hair, the one you abandoned out in the rain a few weeks ago

Phainon sighs to himself at the mess of texts he shot off, each one more fumbling than the previous. He glances up from his phone to watch Mydei, who is staring down at something, eyebrows pinched. He doesn't look very happy, whatever it is. To his dismay, a speech bubble pops up on his screen, signalling that Mydei is typing.

[2:24 pm] Mydei :

I know your name.

[2:24 pm] Phainon:

ok that's good lol i forgot that i hadn't even introduced myself yet

[2:25 pm] Mydei :

Whatever.

Phainon bites down on his bottom lip to temper down a grin as he begins typing again.

[2:25 pm] Phainon:

glad to know ur just as charming over text as in u are in person

[2:25 pm] Mydei :

Delete my number.

[2:25 pm] Phainon:

WAIT

it wasn’t an insult, prmies

promise**

u are extremely charming in your own way

which i like

A few minutes pass without a response, each second stretching on for longer than it should. Phainon taps his fingers against the edge of his phone, watching the screen begin to dim before tapping it again, just to see if Mydei is suddenly typing again. He’s not. There’s nothing - no new messages, no sign of life, no reply - just the last thing he sent, sitting there like a weight in his chest, an unwelcome reminder that he probably said the wrong thing. *Again*.

His jaw tightens as he pockets his phone, giving up for now on rescuing the situation and not wanting to add any more to it. He glances towards the front desk, searching for any sign of Mydei, but the space behind the counter is now empty. The chair is pushed in, the computer screen dark and the desk cleared of the books that were stacked up there before. He’s

gone. Frustration coils in his stomach. He shouldn't care this much. It's just a text, after all, and he's sure that Mydei has simply just gone off to do his *job*, which is far more important than letting Phainon stew in his misery. Still, the silence stings in a way that makes his throat feel tight. He tells himself it doesn't matter, he's gotten this far by making an ass out of himself and *still* scored Mydei's number without even having to ask, so Mydei can't truly hate him - but there's still a chance that Phainon could change that.

With that, he finally allows his phone to fade to black, hiding another one of his mess-ups from sight, and types in his laptop password to get started on some work.

Phainon loses track of time studying after that, furiously typing into a Word document until his wrists ache with the odd angle he's been holding them at for the past few hours. He's a pathetic 127 words under the goal for his essay, which makes him want to repeatedly bang his head against the desk in hopes that'd sort it out for him. He's been over it countless times, rephrasing and adding as much as he can before things stop making sense, and he's completely stumped now.

He groans, dropping his head into his hands. His wrists twinge in protest at the new position but he ignores it in favour of letting his eyes droop shut. They sting, dry from staring at his laptop screen for hours on end. He's tired, spread thin between how much work he still has to do and how little time he has to do it. Phainon's breath warms up his face as he breathes in the small space, more than tempted to allow his exhaustion and frustration to pull him under and sleep for a bit. It'll just be a quick nap, so fast that Mydei won't even catch him and tell him off like before. It's still nowhere

near closing time too, so there's no chance of being threatened to get locked inside again.

Just as he's about to drift off, something cold nudges against his left cheek. He jumps, a squeak leaving his lips as he turns to face the intrusion. Unfortunately, he moves so fast that his chair begins to tip, his sense of gravity thrown off. His mouth opens to yell, stomach swooping when a hand comes slamming down on the back of the chair, immediately righting it again. Phainon's chest heaves, heart racing, as he takes in Mydei in front of him.

One hand is holding onto a bottle of water, the other stretched out behind him, holding Phainon's chair steady. Mydei's shirt sleeves are rolled up to his elbows, showing off the way his muscles flex with power and strength. Protruding lines of veins wrap underneath his skin like vines, which is something Phainon never thought he'd find attractive until now. He's caught between wanting to stare more at his arms and looking at Mydei's face and belatedly chooses the face option, which is staring down at him with a concerned scowl plastered across it. There are faint lines between his eyebrows, making Phainon want to smooth them out with his finger.

"You're fast," Phainon remarks, his heart still beating in his throat, now not just because of almost falling over but because of the man in front of him. "And strong."

Mydei doesn't bother replying to that, which Phainon is secretly glad about. Instead, he removes his hand from the back of Phainon's chair and stands up straight, shoving the water bottle into Phainon's face.

“Here.”

Phainon blinks owlishly at it before he slowly reaches up and grabs the bottle, the ice-cold temperature shocking him awake even more than the fright of almost falling over did. “I thought drinks weren’t allowed in the library?”

“Only if they don’t have a twist cap, which this one does,” Mydei gestures to it, encouraging Phainon to take a sip.

He does. The cool water slides down his dry throat like an oasis, and he downs half the bottle before he can stop himself.

Phainon gasps, licking a stray droplet away from his lips. He looks up at Mydei to find him already looking, staring intently at his mouth. “Thanks.”

The word makes Mydei jolt, his eyes no longer on his mouth but on his eyes. “You’ve been here a while and haven’t moved,” Mydei replies gruffly.

Phainon nods slowly, putting the water bottle down next to his laptop. “Yeah, tough assignment. I still haven’t finished it.”

Mydei leans in, peering at the screen. “Sustainable and eco-friendly materials?”

Phainon sighs, “My favourite topic.” He says flatly.

“Come with me,” Mydei says suddenly and begins walking off before Phainon can reply. He sputters, scrambling up from his chair to chase after Mydei. It reminds him of the scene they made in the cafe, where now instead of coffee tables and patrons, it’s study tables and students they’re weaving around.

Phainon hasn’t been this far into the library before, getting lost amongst the identical shelves that tower above him. Mydei’s back is his only anchor, watching the way his hair sways with each step, his powerful legs striding confidently to wherever it is that they’re going. It’s now that Phainon realises that the tips of Mydei’s hair are reddish, almost strawberry blonde, curling at the ends cutely. Maybe the strawberry emoji he put next to his name wasn’t that bad of a choice, after all.

“This section should have what you need,” Mydei says as they come to a stop, and he turns to face the shelves. His fingers dance across the spines, tracing over the embossed lettering and plastic coverings as he picks one out and hands it over.

Phainon looks down, noting it’s one about sustainability in the eco-engineering world, and takes it, watching as Mydei selects another. It’s captivating watching him work like this, trailing through the books like he knows where every single one is off by heart. By the time Phainon has a stack of three clutched between his hands, weighing him down, Mydei looks rather pleased with himself.

“These should be enough,” Mydei says as he taps the top book’s cover, triumphant.

Phainon winces, barely managing to secure his grip before the precarious stack tilts dangerously close to one side. He scrambles to adjust, fingers slipping against the smooth covers, his breath catching as he fights to keep them tumbling straight to the floor.

Mydei sighs, a touch exasperated, but before Phainon can insist he’s got it, warm hands cup the backs of his, steadying them.

“Are they too heavy?” Mydei asks, voice quiet, closer.

Phainon’s joints lock up. It’s not the weight of the books that’s making his arms tense, his breath suddenly uneven - it’s the press of Mydei’s fingers against his own, the firm but careful way he guides his grip into something more secure. His touch is warm, grounding, and when their fingers begin to detangle, something sharp jolts through Phainon’s chest, catching him completely off guard.

He swears the entire library narrows down to this single point of contact, the warmth of Mydei’s skin against his own, the way their eyes lock, amber meeting blue in the dim lighting filtering through the shelves. The space between them feels tight, as though one sudden movement will snap it like an overwrought rubber band. Phainon can barely breathe, his chest constricting with the lack of oxygen, unable to move and look away, to break the spell he’s under. For a fleeting second, he sees it in Mydei’s eyes.

That softness, the way he’s been caught off guard by their touch, as though he feels something, too. But before he can pry that apart and delve deeper into it, Mydei pulls away.

Immediately, Phainon feels cold, a chill going all the way down to his bones. The absence of his touch is too abrupt, too confusing, sending him into overdrive.

“Be careful,” Mydei murmurs, his voice flat without a hint of concern, though there’s now a tension in his shoulders that wasn’t there before.

Phainon nods on autopilot. His hands feel clammy against the books as he curls his fingers tighter around them, determined to not let Mydei’s assistance go to waste.

“Thanks,” Phainon replies, just as quietly as how Mydei spoke.

Mydei nods back, and Phainon expects him to say something else - maybe a jab at how weak he is (which he isn’t, it’s just hard to fit going to the gym in between his studies), or give him more advice on books he can look at - but Mydei does neither. He doesn’t linger like his touch and simply turns around, stepping away from the pocket of comfort they’d made for themselves, acting as though nothing happened.

Maybe it was nothing, but as Mydei walks away, leaving Phainon with his heart fluttering and warmth still radiating from where their hands touched, he can’t convince himself it's nothing at all.

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading, if you enjoyed, please leave a comment and kudos!!! ヾ(≧▽≦*)o
p.s if you got the 127 pun then ily (stan nct)
-
let's be friends on twitter!!

Chapter 3: chapter three

Chapter Summary

> “So this is what you do on your days off?” Phainon says, eager to talk with the other man.
>
> “Are you following me?” Mydei asks instead of answering.
>
> Phainon laughs, “Please, you *wish* I was that obsessed with you.”
>
> Except, to his dawning realisation, he *is* that obsessed with Mydei.

Chapter Notes

> soooo some of you might've noticed that instead of 3 chapters, there's now 4... yeah. turns out, phaidei brings out the yap in me, and i ended up having to split the rest of the story in half 😅 if not, this one would've been almost 20k words which i was not willing to put out all in one go haha. hopefully having it divided up will make everything flow better!
>
> anyway, happy reading everyone! unedited as usual, so there might be some mistakes.
>
> enjoy! (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Phainon is back at his dorm, essay finally submitted, and the stack of books he’d borrowed from the library piled high on his desk. They teeter dangerously on top of each other as if a sneeze would be enough to make them topple over. Phainon sighs, slumps in his desk chair, and pokes at the spine of the one in the middle. The pile doesn’t fall over, but it sways ominously. He hadn’t read much from any of them, but the bits found relevant to his essay did help. He should be happy that he’s done it again:

completed all his work for the week by the skin of his teeth, yet the victory doesn't seem as sweet as knowing how Mydei's hands feel on his.

The warmth still clings to his skin, phantom-like, refusing to fade. Phainon lifts his hands, turning them over in the low light as if searching for proof that Mydei had touched him there at all. His eyes trace the curve of his knuckles, the crescents of his cuticles, before flipping them over, palms up and fingers splayed.

Nothing.

No mark left behind, no evidence of that fleeting touch. Yet, as his forefinger drifts across the faint lines etched into his palm, he swears they *feel* different - like something unseen has settled beneath his skin, altering it in some quiet, irreversible way. The sensation hums there, just beyond the surface, stubborn and unseen no matter how hard he looks. Phainon swallows, finger coming to a stop at the love line on his palm, taking extra care to follow it from start to end. He taps over it, his fingers curling slightly when it tickles. He wonders idly how Mydei's hands would feel elsewhere - maybe on his face, tangled in his hair or laced through his fingers, using the grip to pull them closer and closer until they're chest to chest, breaths mingling.

With a start, Phainon snaps out of it. He slaps his cheeks between his palms, the sting welcomed as he wills his face to cool down. He's glad that there's no one here to see him blushing up to the roots of his hair. In a bout of shame, he glances towards the library books, his only witnesses. He swivels around on his chair, putting his back towards them as their spines glare holes into the back of his head. To give himself something to do, he picks up his phone lying at the foot of his bed and thumbs through his

notifications, stopping when he spots the text messaging app. He opens it up to his and Mydei's conversation where his glaring mistake from earlier is still there, no less present than before.

It's not *that* late, and considering the library shuts at midnight, surely Mydei will still be awake. It's not even 11 pm yet. Phainon wants to text him so badly, but he's not sure what to say. Mydei doesn't seem the type to enjoy casual conversation or pointless small talk, but he has nothing else to go on. They're not close enough to ask soul-searching questions, or more personal ones about his background. He's curious, desperately so, and wants to know everything about Mydei as quickly as he can consume it.

Baby steps, Phainon thinks and begins to type out a message.

[10:37 pm] Phainon:

thanks for the books, they rly helped

He doesn't expect an immediate response, but that doesn't stop him from checking his phone every few minutes, unable to help himself. It sits beside him on the desk, the screen dark and silent, yet it practically begs for his attention, beckoning him to take another look. Every time he glances at it, his pulse jumps slightly, anticipation curling low in his stomach, only to settle back into disappointment when there's nothing new.

Minutes stretch into hours and nothing changes. He groans, finally giving up and tosses his phone back onto his bed so it's out of reach, convinced that Mydei is either ignoring him (fair enough) or severely regretting ever

giving him his number (also fair enough). As he turns back to his laptop, he hears it, a *ping* signalling a text.

Phainon rockets out of his chair so fast that it wobbles dangerously, nearly toppling over in protest. He doesn't care. Adrenaline propels him forward, and with all the grace of an overly excited puppy, he vaults over the back of it, landing on his bed with an unceremonious bounce. His knee smacks against the edge of the mattress, hitting the wooden bedframe, but the dull pain barely even registers as his eyes lock hungrily on his phone, screen glowing tantalisingly on the sheets.

He allows the momentum to carry him, lunging forward and grabbing at the device like a man starved, fingers fumbling in his desperation. The phone nearly slips out of his grasp, but he recovers quickly, trying to flatten his facial expression from eagerness to neutrality so his Face ID can recognise him. He clutches at it tightly, waiting patiently for the screen to unlock and open into his messages. His heart is hammering, his breath shallow, and in a startling moment of clarity, he realises that he probably looked like he was in the throes of some dramatic action movie sequence - except, instead of dodging bullets, he was just trying to read a text.

Still, as his eyes focus and confirm that Mydei has replied to him, the stakes feel just as high.

[12:01 am] Mydei :

That's what they're there for.

It’s short and sweet, simple and to the point, and so, *so* good. Phainon can almost hear Mydei saying it to his face, picturing the way he’d look as he said it: arms crossed, eyes narrowed behind his glasses, lips pressed in a straight line. Phainon groans out loud, head dipping forward in shame. He wants Mydei so badly that it’s making him go crazy, practically hallucinating voices and seeing things that aren’t there.

Determined to not let an opportunity go to waste, Phainon thinks, ideas bubbling and swirling in his brain until he finally hatches a plan. His plan isn’t one for the faint of heart or the less dedicated, but he’s neither of those things, so he’s convinced it’ll work. It *has* to.

Phainon’s plan unfolds slowly, just as he intended. It stretches across days, then weeks, eventually bleeding into springtime, settling into place as naturally as the lengthening days and the blooming of fresh flowers. Without really thinking about it past surface level, he’s made Mydei a part of his daily routine - which, in turn, means that he must be a part of Mydei’s, too.

The first part of his plan is texting.

Every day, without fail, he sends Mydei a message. Sometimes it’s as simple as a *good morning* or *good night*, a quiet, persistent presence in his inbox. Other times, when he’s feeling braver, he’ll send a photo - blurry snapshots of his Word documents, the sun rising in streaks of pink and gold that secretly remind him of Mydei’s blushing face and eyes, a fleeting

moment captured during his walks to lectures, or even just a stupid cat meme he found online.

It’s the cat memes that get the most out of Mydei, breaking them out of his cycle of clipped replies and pulling something more from him - a full sentence, a wry comment, or, on the best days, a *reaction*. A thumbs-up emoji. A crying laughing face. A love heart. The latter sends Phainon’s own heart into a frantic tailspin, and he has to physically stop himself from over-analysing what it could mean. The heart isn’t meant for *him*, it’s meant for the cute fluffy kitten, which stupidly, he feels jealous of.

And the final part of his plan, inevitably, is the library visits. Those are more subtle and more carefully planned. Phainon tells himself repeatedly that it's not suspicious to turn up so often - he’s an engineering student, so of course, he needs to study and a quiet place to write essays - but he knows damn well that *need* has nothing to do with it. It’s simply all so he can catch a glimpse of Mydei, strike up more conversations with him in person, and borrow more books that he doesn’t even read, all so he can have more excuses to seek him out. The moments between them are brief, but they’re enough to keep Phainon coming back, over and over again, as his slow, careful plan continues to take root.

[11:17 am] Phainon:

hey mydei

are you at the library today?

[11:20 am] Mydei :

No. It’s my day off.

Phainon exhales heavily, staring down at his phone before pocketing it with a sigh that feels too dramatic, even for him. He scuffs his trainers against the pavement as he stalls, lingering outside the lecture hall as if standing here long enough might magically change the fact that Mydei isn’t at the library today.

He doesn’t know what to do with himself now. He’d already sat through his only class today, and he’d *planned* to spend the rest of it at the library - not that he’d admit to anyone that his studying was secondary to simply being near Mydei. Even from a distance, just existing in the same place as him had become part of his routine, a quiet comfort he hadn’t realised he relied on until now. It was a fair trade: he got to see his crush *and* be productive at the same time. It was a win-win. This? This is a lose-lose; no Mydei, no studying.

This throws a wrench in everything. He’d been lucky the past few weeks, his schedule aligning perfectly with Mydei’s shifts, but he supposed that streak had to end at some point. Still, he’s surprised by the pang of disappointment settling in his chest, heavier than it should be considering he can easily see him another time. Shaking it off the best he can, he runs through his options: he could go back to his dorm, or maybe hang out in the common area and see if there’s any new campus gossip floating around. Neither seems to hold much appeal to him, stuck between spending time on his own or around people who aren’t *Mydei*.

Then, another idea pops into his head. The cafe.

A warm drink, something sweet to eat alongside it - yeah, that sounds better than moping around. Maybe it'll even lift his mood a little, and that'll be even better. Without giving himself time to overthink it past that, he adjusts the strap of his bag over his shoulder and heads off towards it.

As the bell above the door jingles, Phainon steps inside, immediately enveloped by the warm, familiar scent of coffee and cinnamon. The rich aroma is comforting enough to ease the disappointment still lingering in his chest, and he's very glad he decided to come here.

The cafe is bustling, every table occupied with students hunched over laptops, friends chatting over half-finished pastries and the occasional solitary person scrolling on their phone. Phainon rocks onto his tiptoes, scanning the back of the room in search of an open seat. He doesn't mind sitting by strangers, per se, but he'd much rather have a spot of his own. But instead of finding an empty table, his gaze lands on something - or rather, *someone* - much more appealing.

Blonde hair catches the soft glow of the cafe lights, a pair of black-framed glasses perched on a familiar nose, a book held effortlessly in one hand. Phainon's breath hitches, pulse thundering in his ears. *Mydei*. He barely hesitates. The moment he spots the librarian tucked into the corner of the cafe, he's moving - forgetting all about his own order. His feet carry him forward before his mind fully catches up, following the magnetic pull tugging at him to come closer.

Mydei is exactly how Phainon always pictured him: alone, absorbed in a book, fingers gently holding the spine with a delicacy that comes from attentiveness. His other hand cradles a mug, steam curling lazily into the air. He looks comfortable, settled into the worn leather of the sofa like he's been there for hours. Maybe he has, and Phainon's about to ruin his solitude by interrupting him. He hates how badly he wants to be a part of it - to sit beside him, to disrupt whatever peace Mydei has wrapped himself in just so he can be included within.

Phainon doesn't think, doesn't second-guess himself. He stops in front of Mydei's seat, waiting patiently to be noticed by a pair of amber eyes that eventually drag themselves away from the pages of his book. For a moment, there's no recognition, just mild surprise at being disturbed, until it turns into something else, softening the corners of Mydei's sharp eyes and sharper lips.

"So this is what you do on your days off?" Phainon says, eager to talk with the other man.

"Are you following me?" Mydei asks instead of answering.

Phainon laughs, "Please, you *wish* I was that obsessed with you."

Except, to his dawning realisation, he *is* that obsessed with Mydei. Thankfully, Mydei doesn't deign him with a response to that, opting to raise an eyebrow and let out a noncommittal hum.

Mydei jerks his chin upwards, “No hot chocolate today?”

Phainon shrugs, “Haven’t made up my mind on what I wanna order yet.” A minor lie, but one he can’t get called out on. He leans over to peer into Mydei’s mug, taking in the bright red liquid. “Pomegranate milk again?”

“Yes, but I asked them to warm it up this time,” Mydei extends his arm, offering it to him. “Try it.”

Phainon hesitates for only a second, blinking a few times in shock, before wrapping his fingers around the handle to bring it towards him. His eyes flicker up to meet Mydei’s, searching, testing. Slowly, making sure that Mydei’s eyes are still on him and only him, he deliberately twists the mug in his grasp, aligning his lips with the exact spot that Mydei’s had just been. His gaze never wavers as he takes a sip, the warm liquid coating his tongue. It’s a lot nicer than he expected it to be. It’s sweet, but not overwhelmingly so, and he hums in quiet approval before giving the mug back. His fingers purposely brush against Mydei’s as he does, the simple touch sending a shiver down his spine.

Mydei doesn’t look away either. He accepts the mug with the same steady ease as it was offered to him, tilting it towards his lips. Phainon watches, entranced, as Mydei takes another sip - from the exact same place that Phainon just had. Phainon’s heart jackrabbits in his chest, the pit of his stomach swirling dangerously. He grits his teeth as Mydei places the mug back down on the table, watching as he swipes his tongue across his bottom lip to catch a stray drop of milk. It makes his lips look even pinker than before, the pomegranate syrup staining them slightly. Phainon wants to reach out and grab him by the chin, tilting his head back just enough that he can sweep in and kiss him, licking the taste of the fruity milk right out of

his mouth. He wonders how much nicer it’ll taste then, how much sweeter it’d be, how -

“Good?” Mydei’s voice interrupts his thoughts.

“Yeah,” Phainon replies, suspiciously breathy. He clears his throat, “Very sweet, just like you.” He throws on at the end, sending Mydei a blinding smile along with it.

Mydei grimaces, completely unphased. “Flirt.”

“Only just noticed?” Phainon replies, strangely emboldened after their indirect kiss.

Mydei’s eyes glow with mirth, lips tugging up ever so slightly in the corners. Phainon wants to *consume* him.

“You’re not exactly subtle.”

“Is that why you gave me your number?” Phainon asks, genuinely curious.

“No,” Mydei replies and doesn’t elaborate. He gestures towards the front counter instead, “Go and order before you get kicked out for loitering.”

“Can I come back and sit with you?”

“Do whatever you want.”

“But,” Phainon begins, taking a step closer, hip nudging the side of the table as he crowds into Mydei’s space, their knees knocking together. Mydei looks shocked, lips parted and eyes wide as he looks up at Phainon. It’s a great expression on him, one that Phainon wants to savour, to hide from the rest of the world so only he can see it. “What do *you* want?”

“Doesn’t matter,” Mydei replies, voice hoarse.

“It does,” Phainon rephrases: “It matters to *me* what you want.”

Mydei breathes out, pupils blown as he blinks up at Phainon. He speaks slowly: “I want you to go and get your damn drink and stop pestering me.”

“I can do that,” Phainon grins, “I’ll be back in a bit.”

Mydei waves him off dismissively, immediately going back to his book.

Phainon feels like he’s on cloud nine as he waltzes over to the front counter to put in his order. He doesn’t ask for pomegranate milk as much as he wants to, opting for a simple latte instead. He takes it back to the table, smiling brightly when he sees that Mydei has put his book away. That means that he intends to *talk*, right? Not just read his book and ignore him for the entire time, which is what Phainon expected would happen.

Progress, *progress*, Phainon thinks happily to himself, humming a happy tune as he sits down next to Mydei, their shoulders and thighs touching. He folds one leg over the other, almost giddy with how pleased he is.

“I changed my mind, go sit somewhere else.”

“Oh, c’mon, don’t be a spoilsport,” Phainon chimes, knocking their shoulders together playfully. It gets him the reaction he wants: a scowl and piercing eyes glaring at him.

Phainon takes a cautious sip of his drink to hide his grin, only to realise too late that it’s still too hot. A shocked gasp escapes him as he quickly sticks his tongue out, hoping the cool air will soothe the burn.

“You look like a dog when you do that,” Mydei remarks snidely.

“So mean,” Phainon whines, wincing when his tongue throbs from the burn.

“A latte?” Mydei questions, ignoring Phainon’s insult.

“I usually order this, you just caught me on a bad day when I got the hot chocolate,” Phainon laughs.

Mydei leans into the arm of the chair, away from Phainon, propping his elbow up on it and resting his cheek in the palm of his hand, eyes darting back to him. “Not quite a triple-shot espresso, but it’s an improvement.”

Phainon grumbles, “I still don’t get what you have against hot chocolate when you’re drinking *pomegranate milk*.”

Mydei shrugs, “My mother used to make it for me as a kid, and it just stuck.”

“Oh,” Phainon blinks, a bit taken aback by the sudden personal anecdote. He wasn’t expecting that without purposely prying, so he added this small tidbit into the back of his mind for later. “I’m sure she’s glad you still drink it.”

Mydei’s lips curl into a smile, but there’s no real warmth behind it. It’s the kind of smile that doesn’t quite reach his eyes, one that wavers at the edges as though it’ll crumble at any moment. His gaze is distant, unfocused as if he’s looking past Phainon, past the cafe, past the very moment they’re in.

“She would’ve been happy, yes,” Mydei says, voice hollow.

His fingers tighten ever so slightly around the handle of his mug, knuckles paling from the pressure. For a fleeting second, Phainon sees it - the weight of something unspoken pressing down on him, an open wound that still hasn’t fully healed. Phainon wants to say something, to bridge the space between them and gently bring Mydei back to the present, but the words catch in his throat. What *can* he say? Instead, he watches, giving Mydei a private moment to himself.

Within the next few seconds, his faraway expression is gone, replaced with one that’s far more familiar to Phainon.

To try and lift the mood, Phainon asks: “What were you reading before I came in?”

Mydei blinks before leaning forward and grabbing the book from his bag on the floor. “*Mortal and Divine*, it’s a collection of Greek poetry.”

Phainon takes the book from Mydei’s hands. It’s a worn copy, clear by how the pages are slightly yellowed on the edges, but apart from that, there are no signs of wear and tear. He inspects it, noting the spine is still pristine, not a crease in sight. He flicks through a few pages, being careful not to open it fully and damage it. His eyes trail over the words, them mostly going over his head. Poetry in general isn’t his idea of fun reading, but each poem has a small illustration above it which draws his interest. He lingers on a few that catch his eye until he flips to a full page one. Phainon turns the book horizontally to get a better look at it. An inked illustration shows a lone

figure standing at the entrance of a towering marble temple, their raised arms bathed in blood as they hold up a sword. Faceless gods loom above them in the sky, watching the figure, partially hidden behind clouds.

“Some pretty hard-hitting stuff,” Phainon remarks, closing the book gently and handing it back to Mydei. “Is that from the library?”

“No, it’s from my personal collection,” Mydei takes the book back, the very tips of their fingers touching. It sends an electric shock through Phainon. “It was a gift from my mother.”

Another mention of his mother. The words settle heavily between them, and Phainon feels an almost unbearable pull - a desperate need to reach out, to comfort and to *know*. Every piece of Mydei that he’s been given so far has just been that: a piece. A mere fragment of something much larger, something he hasn’t yet been allowed to see in full.

Phainon wants to ask. The urge claws at his chest, twisting so tight around his lungs that he feels breathless. He wants to know what Mydei’s mother was like, if she was anything like him. He wants to press, to peel back the guarded layers Mydei keeps so firmly in place and see *him*, truly, fully.

But he doesn’t. Because he knows what it’s like to have something sacred and personal pried from his grip when he’s not ready to let it go. He knows the sting of questions asked too soon, the way they can turn a tender memory into something sharp and painful, and the last thing Phainon wants is to be the reason Mydei retreats even more into himself, especially when they’ve come this far already.

So instead, he swallows down his curiosity, his yearning to reach out and tangle their fingers together to squeeze them encouragingly, and lets the moment pass by.

“You’ve taken care of it very well.”

Mydei nods in affirmation, clearly proud of himself. “It’s what inspired me to become a librarian.”

“Oh?” Phainon leans into Mydei, pressing their shoulders together firmly, latte forgotten as he watches the other with a newfound interest. “And not because you wanted to help poor, stressed-out students like me pass their exams?” Phainon jokes, batting his eyelashes dramatically with his words.

Mydei rolls his eyes, turning at the waist to face Phainon. He lands a solid flick to the middle of Phainon’s forehead. It *hurts*, the bastard, and he pouts while he rubs at the sore spot as Mydei settles back down.

“You’re so cruel!”

“You haven’t even seen the half of it, Phainon,” Mydei replies, tone snide.

Phainon freezes. The world around him dulls, fading into a distant hum as all his focus zeroes in on one thing: *his name*, spoken by *Mydei*. His hand falls limply into his lap, fingers slack against the fabric of his jeans, discarded. It takes him a moment to process, to fully grasp the weight of it, but once he does, it settles into his chest like a slow-burning ember.

Phainon has heard his name countless times before: casual greetings from classmates, impatient scoldings from his parents and professors, teasing remarks from Castorice. But *this* - this is different. It isn't just the sound of it, but the way it lingers, warm and careful, shaped by Mydei's deep voice and delicate lips. His throat tightens, pulse thrumming against his skin, too fast, too much.

"I think that's the first time you've ever said my name," Phainon croaks out.

Mydei's expression scrunches up, adjusting the glasses on his face to sit higher on his nose bridge. "I've said your name before."

"No, no you haven't," Phainon wriggles around on the sofa. He's elated, even more so than when Mydei allowed him to sit next to each other. He wants more, no - he *needs* more.

He has to hear it again.

"Say it again."

Mydei side-eyes him with venom, but there's none of it present as he speaks. "You really are a dog. If I say your name, will you sit and roll over?"

"Sure, whatever you want."

"I don't want that," Mydei spits out. "Finish your drink and be quiet."

Phainon laughs loudly, the sound echoing throughout the cafe as he picks up his now cold drink, gulping it down all in one go. After that, they chat for longer, jumping between topics and conversations.

"How did you get into engineering?" Mydei asks, head tilted in curiosity.

Phainon practically glows under the attention, his chest swelling with something warm and uncontainable. He tries to keep his expression neutral, to not wear it all out in the open, but the beaming smile still widens his mouth regardless. It's intoxicating, the way Mydei looks at him, waiting patiently for his answer. Mydei isn't just making polite conversation; he wants to know more - about his studies, about his past, about *him*. Phainon wants to tell him everything, from the late nights he spends hunched over his notes to the excitement he feels when he finally solves a tricky equation. Phainon is more than happy to give it all to him. The words build in his throat, tripping over themselves until he has to swallow them all back down and make sure he starts from the beginning.

“My dad had this shed in our back garden,” Phainon starts simply, leaning back into the sofa. “It was full of model trains and aeroplanes - like, proper detailed ones with little replica engines and everything.”

“Yeah?” Mydei says encouragingly.

“Yeah,” Phainon nods, his bright grin dimming into a small smile as he begins to feel nostalgic. “I used to mess around with them all the time, take them apart, figure out how they worked. I probably ruined a few in the process, but my dad never got mad about it. He just kept showing me how to put them back together again.”

Mydei hums quietly, glancing at him over the rim of his mug. It must be practically empty now after they’d been talking for so long. “So that’s how it all started?”

“Pretty much,” Phainon admits. “Then as I got older, I got more into the ecological side of it. I guess I never grew out of wanting to take things apart and see what makes them tick.”

Mydei nods, his quiet encouragement urging Phainon to keep talking, the conversation stretching effortlessly into the late afternoon. Time slips away unnoticed, the golden light outside gradually fading until the overhead lights hum softly, casting a glow brighter than the dimming sky.

What surprises Phainon the most isn’t just how long they’ve been talking - it’s how much Mydei actually contributes. He asks thoughtful questions,

genuine interest lacing his tone, and responds with little hums and nods at all the right moments. It's not exaggerated, nothing overt, but it's *there*, and it's enough to send a warm, heady rush through Phainon's veins.

He's not quite used to this - being listened to so raptly while being watched so attentively. Mydei's attention feels like standing under the sun after a long, dark winter, thawing him out in ways he didn't realise he needed. He soaks up every moment greedily, basking in it until his stomach feels full of nothing but butterflies.

"Will you be working tomorrow?" Phainon asks when Mydei checks his watch for the third time within the span of a minute. He gets the hint that it's time to wrap up.

"Yes, I will," Mydei replies, standing up and picking his bag up off the ground.

Phainon rises with him, gathering his stuff as they begin to walk side by side towards the exit.

"I'll see you tomorrow, then," Phainon says hopefully once they're outside, the spring breeze making him shiver under his thin jacket.

Mydei looks cosy in his coat as he sticks his hand into the pockets. "You're almost due on the books you took out."

“I’ll bring them in tomorrow,” Phainon promises as he waves goodbye to Mydei, stepping out from underneath the awning. He’s glad this time it isn’t raining and he can take his time walking home.

He watches as Mydei walks in the opposite direction, and Phainon’s heart feels tugged alongside him, desperately wanting to chase after him.

Phainon does *not,* in fact, bring all the books back the next day. Instead, he strolls into the library with a single one tucked under his arm, making his way to the front desk with an easy grin. With a simple *thud,* he drops it onto the counter, the sound cutting through the quietness of the library.

Mydei barely reacts, but there’s something knowing in the way he eyes Phainon up as he reaches for the book. He flips it open with practised ease, slender fingers skimming over the title page before landing on the barcode.

As Mydei scans it into the system, his expression remains placid, he speaks: “Where are the rest?”

Phainon shrugs, “Whoops, I must’ve forgotten them at home.”

He hadn’t forgotten them at all. In fact, he’d spent 10 minutes this morning debating on which one to return first because bringing them all back at once

would mean fewer excuses to come back, and that? That simply wasn’t an option.

Mydei gives him a double take, lips downturned as he slowly places the book behind him on the returns shelf. Phainon doesn’t stick around, but as he retreats to the exit, he can feel Mydei’s curious gaze watching him.

The next day, Phainon saunters into the library, a pep in his step as he practically glides across the floor towards Mydei. The second book is tucked under his arm like a prized possession. He spots Mydei at the front desk, already absorbed in his work, fingers tapping against the keyboard as he scans through returns. At his arrival, Mydei regards him with suspicion, eyes narrowed and lips pursed as he slowly takes the book from Phainon’s outstretched hands.

“And the final one?” Mydei asks, scanning the barcode until it beeps. “Remember, you only have tomorrow left before it’s overdue.”

“I know,” Phainon responds vaguely, grinning. He turns around, already making his way to leave. “I’ll be back for it then, don’t you worry.”

On the third day, Phainon brings in the last book. It weighs heavy in his hands as he walks up to the front desk, relieved to see Mydei sitting behind

it. He’s occupied this time, phone held up to his ear. He quickly spots Phainon approaching and holds up one hand to signal to wait. Phainon remains silent, listening in one-half of the conversation.

“I see, then I’m very sorry for your loss,” Mydei says, eyebrows furrowed. “Of course, I’ll wipe it from the system now. Goodbye.”

Phainon raises a surprised eyebrow when Mydei slams the phone down, grumbling as he begins to furiously type something into the computer.

“What was that about?” Phainon questions, his curiosity getting the better of him.

“Did you know,” Mydei begins, teeth gritted so tightly that Phainon can see a muscle jump in his jaw. “That some students get their friends to pretend that they’ve died so they can get out of paying late fees?”

“I’m sorry, *what*?” Phainon replies incredulously.

“This is the fourth time it’s happened just this term,” Mydei snaps, hands pausing on the keyboard as he shuts his eyes, breathing in and out deeply to calm himself. “These kids think I don’t recognise them when they come slinking back into the library to study. *Passed away*, my ass.”

Phainon snickers, hiding it quickly behind the back of his hand when Mydei tosses a deadly glare his way. “You gotta admit, it’s quite brave of them to do that.”

“If it was my choice, I’d have them banned from using the resources here, but that’s sadly not my decision,” Mydei grumbles.

“Then I’m sure you’ll be pleased to know that I brought my final book back, on time, while still perfectly alive,” Phainon says, placing said book down on the front desk with an exaggerated flourish.

Mydei gives him a flat look, unimpressed, but takes the book anyway to scan. “Is playing dead not one of the tricks you’ve learned yet?”

“If you want me to bark that badly, just say so,” Phainon pauses, resting his folded arms on the front desk and placing his chin on top, looking at Mydei pleadingly through his eyelashes. “I’ll even get on my knees and beg for you.”

Going by Mydei’s poignant silence and bright pink ears, Phainon assumes he heard the innuendo. He fights down a smirk.

“Hm, maybe I should’ve saved that one for our third date?”

Mydei drops the book onto the table with a bang, glaring at him through his glasses. His eyes are ablaze, vibrant and bright, but Phainon feels something hot tug behind his navel at the attention.

“You’d have to take me on two dates prior to that, and as far as I’m concerned, you’ve not even started on the first one yet.”

Phainon pouts, standing up straight again. He sniffs haughtily, “Our cafe meet-ups don’t count?”

“No,” Mydei replies snidely. “You didn’t even offer to pay for my drink.”

“*You’re* the one with the job, not me. I’m just a broke uni student,” Phainon replies petulantly.

“Then I suppose that just means you can’t handle me,” Mydei says.

Phainon’s eyes narrow, stomach bubbling as the threat of a challenge arises between them. He steps closer, wanting to be even more in Mydei’s space despite the desk between them, not even flinching when the wood digs into his ribs uncomfortably.

He leans in, “Trust me, I can handle you.”

Mydei smirks, reclining in his chair with an effortless sort of grace that comes with natural cockiness, acting as though he owns not just the chair but the entire room. His arms fold across his chest, the motion drawing Phainon's attention downward. Mydei's wearing a simple black shirt today, nothing particularly flashy, but somehow, on him, it looks absolutely devastating. Especially with the way that the first few buttons are undone, giving him a clear view of defined collarbones and a hint of red tattoos, along with a first-row seat at the way his pecs press together, a shadow forming between them, teasing a depth and definition that makes Phainon want to *bite*. Phainon swallows thickly, the pit of his stomach swirling. His gums begin to itch with the urge to bite down, to mark, to *claim*. It's an overwhelming, visceral need, something that coils low and dangerously as sparks along his fingertips feel like static before a storm. His eyes trace the sharp line of Mydei's collarbones, the way they disappear beneath the open collar of his shirt, half-hidden but begging to be touched, to be *tasted*. He wants to lean in and press his teeth against that pale stretch of skin, to leave an imprint - proof that he was there, that Mydei is *his*.

Phainon's hands begin to sweat, fingers twitching with the aching urge to reach out, to slip past the loose fabric and feel the warmth of Mydei's skin beneath his palm. It would be so easy. Just the simplest movement to reach over and he'd be *there*, his hand splayed across Mydei's chest, feeling the slow rise and fall of his breath, feeling the powerful muscles move in tandem. Would Mydei stop him? Would he shudder at his touch, at the heat of Phainon's palm pressing flush against him? Would he *like* it, arching up for more?

"Eyes up here, dog," Mydei drawls, and Phainon obeys, a groan stuck in his throat at the command as he slowly drags his eyes back up to meet Mydei's.

"Just you wait, Mydei, I'll -"

“Um, excuse me?” A timid voice comes from behind Phainon. He turns around, startled by the sudden intrusion. It’s a girl his age, looking between them nervously as she grips a large textbook in her arms. “Sorry for interrupting, but can I check this out really quickly? I need to leave now or I’ll be late for my lecture.”

“Sorry,” Phainon apologises, smiling serenely as he moves out of the way to let her go in front. He doesn’t snap at her that there’s a self-scanning checkout right next to her, but it’s a close call. Instead, he breathes out, rolling his shoulders to rid them of the tension that's built up during his and Mydei’s exchange.

Phainon peers around her, waving at Mydei. “I’ll see you later.”

“Wait, Phainon -” Mydei’s voice cuts off as Phainon stops being able to hear him, already halfway towards the exit.

A few days pass where Phainon doesn’t text Mydei, and he doesn’t go to see him either. Each time he thinks about it, about pressing send on a text or stepping into the library, something sharp twists inside him, sour and unnerving. He feels completely out of sorts, thrown off balance by the last time they were together.

The memory replays in his head, again and again. The slow, deliberately chosen words swapped between them. The desperation that clawed at his throat to touch, the scent of Mydei's cologne sweetening the particles in the air. The tension was so thick that Phainon wanted to melt into it until there was nothing left of him. Phainon had barely registered what was going on outside of their bubble until a voice cut through the tension, pulling Mydei's attention elsewhere, away from *him*, breaking the moment into tiny, irretrievable pieces.

Were they *flirting*? Was that what he could call it now, a name to their conversations and back and forths? The thought makes his face burn, and yet, he can't deny that more recently things feel *changed* between them. More deliberate, more intense, more… *real*. The teasing aspect had always been present but mixed in with attraction and a magnetic charge that seems to be pulling them both closer - not just Phainon - it makes him feel raw and exposed.

So, he does nothing. He ignores the library, ignores his phone, tells himself he's giving it time to blow over, that Mydei probably doesn't feel the same anyway and that it's all in his head. His perfectly plotted plan begins to fall apart, brick by brick, crumbling around him into dust. Maybe he isn't as strong as he thought he was, maybe in the face of something so real he can practically reach out and touch, that's where it ends for him. The neverending thoughts don't quell the restlessness building up inside of him. It doesn't stop the way his fingers hover over his screen, tempted to type something, *anything*, just for another moment of Mydei's attention. And it definitely doesn't stop the sinking feeling in his chest when he remembers the way Mydei had called out his name as he was leaving, panicked and confused.

The thing is, Phainon *likes* Mydei. That much is sure. He likes their banter and sly remarks, likes the way Mydei reacts to him, hissing and spitting like

a startled cat. He likes the way Mydei's hair glows softly in the light, his eyes bright and shining even behind his glasses. He likes the slope of his nose, the plushness of his lips and the sharp cuts of his muscles. He likes it when Mydei lets him in - offering small tidbits and parts of himself that Phainon never would've guessed before. It makes him feel warm inside, special and cared for.

But he's not sure if Mydei likes him back.

He doesn't want to waste his time chasing after someone who doesn't want him - not the way that he wants Mydei. The thought alone is enough to make his chest ache, a dull, persistent weight pressing on his heart. He's never been one to pine, never let himself get too caught up in wanting what he can't have. But Mydei is different. He's managed to dig himself into Phainon's life so seamlessly that the idea of stepping back and pulling away for good feels impossible.

Even if Mydei's feelings don't mirror his own, Phainon knows he'd still want to keep him close. He enjoys his company too much - values the quiet moments, the shared looks, and the dry humour that so often catches him off guard. Mydei challenges him in ways no one else does, and the thought of losing that - of losing *him* - is unbearable. But he can't deny that it would hurt. That every interaction, every brush of their shoulders and every accidental touch would sting with the reminder of what could've been but never was. Could Phainon truly settle for that? Could he face Mydei head on, shoulders straight and head held high?

The answer should be easy. It should be a simple *yes*, that he'd do all that for a chance to stay within Mydei's orbit for a second longer, but then his heart clenches and stomach turns and he's not so sure anymore.

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading, if you enjoyed, please leave a comment and kudos!!! ヾ(≧▽≦*)o the final chapter is already finished but needs A LOT of editing, so any love given would really help motivate me

-

thanks to my bestie for giving me the anecdote about the library fees... it was too funny not to incorporate into this 😭

-

let's be friends on x/twitter! i post fic updates/previews, and lots about phaidei ^_^ let's be moots

Chapter 4: chapter four

Chapter Summary

> “Do you stargaze every night?” Phainon asks when Mydei is finished listing the names of the stars.
>
> “Only when I feel like it,” Mydei replies. “Most of the time, it’s too cloudy.” He shifts then, not further away but closer, pressing their shoulders together more firmly. “I’ve never shared this with anyone else before.”
>
> Phainon’s breath catches in his throat, heart stuttering and then starting again. His stomach floods with butterflies, their wings as gentle as dandelion seeds in the wind. “Then, I’m glad you shared it with me.”

Chapter Notes

> aaaah, it's here!! the final chapter .·´¯`(>▂<)´¯`·.
>
> thank you for all the support so far! it helped motivate me so much and i'm eternally grateful
>
> also, i know nothing about stargazing/stars in general, everything i wrote here was courtesy of a thorough google search lmao.
>
> unbeta'd, so there might be some mistakes.
>
> enjoy (´▽`ʃ♡ƪ)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Days pass, and Phainon lies in bed, staring at the dark ceiling, his mind an unrelenting storm of thoughts that just won’t settle. He shifts onto his side, then onto his back again, tugging the duvet up to his chin before kicking it off entirely. Nothing helps. His thoughts are running in circles around him,

each one louder than the last, demanding to be resolved without offering any solutions.

He considers messaging Castorice, and he’s tempted to grab his phone off his bedside table until he remembers that she’s knee-deep in a group project right now, battling annoying teammates and drowning in deadlines. The last thing he wants to do is to disturb her during all that by piling his own mess on top of hers. He’s already taken up so much of her time with this through text, updating her whenever something new happens between him and Mydei - a new touch, a new shared joke, a new lingering glance.

Still, the urge to vent, to spill everything that’s been clogging up his chest for the past few days, is unbearable. He sighs, pressing the heels of his palms against his eyes as if that might stop the ache. His heart feels too full, his emotions a tangled knot he doesn’t know how to unravel. He wants to talk to someone. He wants to be given a magic spell that will fix all this. He misses Mydei, and as much as he keeps acting as though his problems don’t have an answer, there’s one glowing solution: he should get over himself and reach out again. But more than anything, and before he can do any of that, he wants to know where he stands with Mydei - if this thing between them is real, if it’s worth the way it’s taken up every inch of his brain, leaking into every crevice of his being.

It stings that Mydei hasn’t reached out, either. Was their entire friendship foundation built on Phainon alone, and that all it takes for it to dissipate into a cloud of smoke is his lack of trying? Huffing angrily, he flips over onto his other side, staring intensely at the wall as if that’ll offer up an explanation. Would it kill Mydei to text him first? Or is this just proof that everything Phainon had gotten excited over - what he thought was *progress* between the two of them - wasn’t anything at all?

“Stupid Mydei,” Phainon mutters, reaching an arm out behind him to blindly feel for his phone. It takes a few tries to locate, palm slapping down on the table without direction until his fingers grasp at it.

Sleep is a competition he’s been losing since he last spoke to Mydei, favouring watching silly youtube videos until he passes out rather than actively trying to go to sleep. It’s been working, if he counts falling asleep at 3 am and having to wake up again at 7 am a *working strategy*. Tonight, he’ll do the same, already scrolling to find a mindless video to watch. At least it keeps his mind off things, enough that he can finally fall into a dreamless slumber, ready to be bombarded with his thoughts again once he wakes up.

Phainon’s eyes begin to drift shut 15 minutes into a video about thermodynamics when his phone vibrates. He blinks back awake, curious as to what notification he’s gotten so late at night. It’s probably a spam email, but his eyes catch onto something red before the notification disappears back up into the control centre. *Red*, just like the strawberry emoji next to Mydei’s contact name. His heart leaps in his chest as he drags down the notification bar, face to face with a new text. One from *Mydei.* Phainon’s thumb hovers over it, shaking slightly as he debates whether or not to open it. Isn’t this just what he was ruminating on, saying he wanted Mydei to contact him first? It’s right there, in front of him, a tap away, but suddenly he’s too nervous to look. From the preview alone, it’s a photo and nothing more.

He shakily presses on the notification, bringing their entire conversation into view. Phainon blinks a few times as he looks at the photo. It’s the moon, a perfect silver disc suspended in the midnight expanse, glowing with an ethereal light that softens the darkness around it with its ghostly glow.

It’s a beautiful photo. One that makes Phainon’s eyes widen as he rakes his eyes over it, wanting to take in as much as he can. He gulps down any trepidation and begins to type.

[11:59 pm] Phainon:

whoa it’s so bright

Immediately, his phone buzzes with a response.

[11:59 pm] Mydei :

You can also see Orion too.

[12:00 am] Phainon:

? the constellation?

[12:00 am] Mydei :

Yes.

Mydei sends another photo, this time, focusing solely on the stars. The night sky is pitch black, and small spots of white lights are dotted around the image. Phainon squints and turns his phone on its side before righting it

again, pinching in to zoom and then zooming out as far as he can go. Despite all that, he still can’t see the constellation that Mydei means.

[12:03 am] Phainon:

i can’t see it lol

[12:03 am] Mydei :

The three brightest stars at the centre are Orion’s Belt.

Phainon scrolls up and taps the photo again, and there he sees three small dots that do appear brighter than the rest.

[12:04 am] Phainon:

impressive work for a phone camera

[12:05 am] Mydei :

Thanks.

I enjoy star gazing.

Phainon’s shock at the double texts lasts as long as it takes for him to realise that he’s been offered another small morsel of information about Mydei. One that exists outside of his interest in books and his job as a librarian.

This is more, this is a *hobby*. Never, in all the weeks he's spent exchanging messages with Mydei, has he ever sent two in a row. He's always been reserved as he is in person, calculated with his responses, never giving or taking too much or too little. But here they are, clear as day, stacked on top of each other, offering him the olive branch for conversation that Phainon has so desperately been waiting for.

Phainon's heart stutters, fingers hovering over the keyboard as he wonders what this means.

[12:08 am] Phainon:

i prefer the sun

but stars are pretty too

[12:08 am] Mydei :

Is that why you have a sun tattoo on your neck?

[12:09 am] Phainon:

not telling ;)

[12:09 am] Mydei :

Fine.

[12:10 am] Phainon:

don’t sulk lol

it’s kind of a boring story why i got it

[12:10 am] Mydei :

I don’t mind.

There it is again - another thread for Phainon to grasp at, another opening Mydei has unknowingly (or knowingly?) left for him. He could let it slip through his fingers, pretend he never saw it and leave the conversation to fizzle out on its own. It’d be easy enough to stop replying, to claim he fell asleep or say that the story wasn’t even worth telling. He’s sure Mydei wouldn’t push for more details and pry.

Phainon gnaws at his lip, his thumbs hovering over the keyboard once more, stumped. His mind plays out both scenarios - one where he dismisses it with a half-hearted excuse, and another where he takes the risk. He swallows, pulse thrumming under his skin as he backs out of the chat, ready to close it. Instead, before he can talk himself out of it, he taps on Mydei’s contact and presses down on the call button. The ringing begins instantly, each one feeling like an aeon as time slows to a stop. It goes on, and Phainon wonders if Mydei will pick up at all.

Then, a click.

“Phainon?”

Mydei's voice - right there, real and close, oozing through the speakers like honey. Just one word and Phainon is back to square one, drowning in it, in *him*, in the way his name sounds when spoken in that voice. It's softer like this, quieter, lacking the usual sharpness Phainon has grown accustomed to. Stripped of the careful restraint Mydei so often wears like armour, it feels… *intimate*.

The sound curls around him, settling in his chest where it takes up residence like it's always belonged there. Phainon grips his phone a little harder, pressing it harsher into his ear as if that'll dissipate the physical distance between them. His breath catches before he can stop it, his throat clicking audibly enough to be heard through the phone line. Phainon already wishes he could see him - wishes he could read his expression, watch his lips move around the syllables of his name, confirm that this moment is as real as it feels. But all he has for now is this voice, warm and low, threading through the quietness of his dorm, carving a space in the silence.

"Mydei, hey," Phainon says eventually, wanting to say his name too to complete the cycle between them. "I thought calling you would be easier, I was getting tired of typing."

Mydei hums, the sound deep and comforting. The hair on the back of his neck rises - it's only been a few days without hearing his voice, but it comes right back to him, causing a twisty feeling in his stomach. The empty beat of his heart suddenly becomes more vibrant, flourishing under the sound of Mydei's voice.

"That's fine," Mydei replies, the line slightly distorted by a rustling sound.

“Oh, are you in bed? Sorry, I should’ve asked before phoning.”

“No, it’s -” The rustling stops. “I am in bed, but it’s okay.”

“Okay,” Phainon echoes and turns over, swapping the phone to his other hand to accommodate his new position.

He can almost feel it, the picture so clear in his head - Mydei lying next to him in his bed, their foreheads nearly brushing with proximity, the atmosphere bending around them like a cocoon. The night chill wouldn’t dare creep in, not when Mydei’s warmth lingers between them, his breath fanning softly against Phainon’s skin. Their voices would be quiet, meant only for each other, drifting through the dark like ripples on still water. Every whispered word would be a thread pulling them closer, every pause filled with something unspoken, something felt. And Mydei’s words - steady, warm, real - would be the only thing grounding Phainon, keeping him from floating away entirely.

“So why the sun tattoo?” Mydei asks, breaking the silence when Phainon doesn’t reply.

“It’s all to do with Greek mythology,” Phainon begins, clearing his throat and coming back to reality. “My name derives from the mythological figure *Phaenon*, which then also in turn comes from an Ancient Greek term… which, uh, I can’t remember right now. I’d probably butcher the pronunciation anyway,” Phainon chuckles to himself self-deprecatingly.

“But either way, it means *to shine*, and my mother always calls me her little sun. So, it just made sense to get something related.”

“The sky god of Cronus?” Mydei responds.

“Huh?”

Mydei huffs, but it’s not exasperated. It’s *fond*. “The figure, Phaenon, he’s the sky god of Cronus, which means ‘Saturn’, like the planet.”

“Oh,” Phainon feels a little silly for not having known that. He hadn’t done much research into his name past what his mother and father told him as a kid.

“The name suits you well,” Mydei replies. “Saturn is a bright planet, easy to spot when you’re looking.”

“I’m… easy to spot?” Phainon repeats hesitantly, confused.

“No,” Mydei begins, the tone of his voice softening. “You shine brightly.”

“Now who’s flirting?” Phainon replies, breathless.

“Humph, if that’s how you’re going to take it, then I won’t stop you.”

“You won’t?” Phainon asks, any remnants of sleep immediately disappearing. He’s wide awake, alert, and on edge. He was kidding, but is Mydei… really flirting with him right now? And admitting it?

“No,” Is the simple reply he gets back.

It’s enough. It’s more than enough. It’s so much more than he could’ve ever imagined.

He sinks into his pillow, giddy and slightly dizzy with relief and *want*. “Ah, Mydei, you’re making it difficult to not come and see you tomorrow at the library...”

“Then don’t hold back,” Mydei says. “I’ll be there anyway.”

Phainon wants to bite his knuckles, maybe even his entire fist, just to physically stop himself from yelling *I’ll be there!!!!* In response. He considers turning over and shoving his face into his pillow, screaming himself hoarse until his vocal cords give out - but with his luck, his dorm neighbour would think he’s being murdered and call security. Punching something seems like another solid option: his mattress? Too soft. His bedside table? Too sturdy. His own stupid face? Too tempting. He groans,

not caring if Mydei hears, and by the small amused huff he gets, he definitely does.

“I’ll see you tomorrow then,” Phainon says instead of doing any of those things, desperately trying to reign in his frazzled emotions.

“I’ll find you some books about constellations,” Mydei says. “Then I can show you a better picture of Orion.”

“Or I could just google it,” Phainon counters.

“You could…” Mydei trails off ominously. “But then you wouldn’t get to spend time with me.”

Phainon splutters, launching upright in his bed. “Mydei -!”

“Goodnight, Phainon.”

And with that, the call ends.

Phainon stares at his blank phone screen, his shocked reflection mirrored back at him. His name, *again,* from Mydei…

Oh dear, he thinks as he falls back down, cradling his phone gently to his chest as he stares up at the ceiling. *I'm so, so fucked*.

Phainon's day has barely begun and it was already a disaster. He woke with a jolt, heart hammering in his chest as he registered the time glowing accusingly from his phone screen - ten minutes until class started. After his phone conversation with Mydei last night, he'd forgotten to turn his alarm on for the morning, resulting in this major mess up.

"Shit," He hisses, flinging his covers off as he scrambles out of bed in a flurry of tangled limbs.

There's no time for his usual morning routine, no carefully chosen outfit or *good morning* text to Mydei. Instead, he yanks on the first hoodie and pair of jeans he can find, and shoves his feet into his trainers - no socks, because who had time for *socks*? - and bolts out the door, bag half-zipped and hair sticking up at all angles.

The sprint across campus is brutal. His lungs burned, his legs protested with every step, and the cold morning air did nothing to wake him up properly - it just left him shivering as he burst through the lecture hall doors, fifteen minutes late and completely out of breath.

And, of course, at the front of the room was his least favourite professor.

“Well, well,” His professor drawls, voice echoing off the high ceiling. “How generous of you to grace us with your presence, Mr. Phainon. Please, by all means, take your time. We wouldn’t want to *rush* you.”

Heat crawls up Phainon’s neck as a hundred pairs of eyes all turn toward him. He wants the ground to open up and swallow him whole. Maybe if he walked out right now, dropped out of university and moved to a remote island, he could forget this public shaming had ever happened. But said remote island wouldn’t have Mydei, so that’s off the table.

Instead of all that, he swallows his pride, ducking his head in apology and hurries toward the back of the room. A few students shoot him sympathetic looks as he goes. It’s hard to concentrate on the lecture after that as he’s too busy wallowing in secondhand embarrassment and making a silent vow to never, ever forget to set his alarm again, no matter how distracting Mydei is.

It only gets worse when lunchtime rolls around. Phainon just wants a drink - something cold and refreshing to wash down the lingering taste of humiliation from this morning. But, of course, fate isn’t on his side today.

The vending machine hums mockingly as the bottle he’s paid for remains stubbornly wedged between the shelf and the glass, taunting him. He stares at it for a moment, despondent, praying to somehow gain psychic abilities that’ll make him able to move it to the tray at the bottom. When that

inevitably fails, he resorts to the time-honoured method of brute force, giving the machine a solid kick.

Nothing.

Another kick, harder this time. The machine rattles, but the drink doesn’t budge.

Phainon exhales through his nose to cut off the sharp rise of anger building inside him. He presses his forehead against the cool glass in defeat, his eyes slipping shut for a brief moment.

In and out, he encourages himself, *breathe in and out.*

He pushes off the vending machine, walking away from his still-stuck drink without another glance.

And, of course, if his day couldn’t get any worse (which he really thought it couldn’t) he’s proven wrong at exactly 4 pm when the final lecture of his day finished.

“Hey, Phainon…” One of his classmates, Sophia, begins as she slides up beside him.

He glances at her out of the corner of his eyes, trying to focus on packing his equipment up.

“What’s up?” Phainon asks.

“So you know the group project that’s due on Monday…” Sophia trails off.

He turns to her, eyebrows drawn. “Yeah, what about it? Is the PowerPoint finished?”

“About that,” Sophia laughs, reaching her hands out to pat him on the back. “None of us have time over the weekend to work on it, and there’s a bunch of evidence in there without any citations. So… we were just wondering if you’d be able to handle it instead?”

Phainon’s confused expression turns into one of anger. “Are you kidding? Nico said he’d finished it ages ago, and I already did most of the work to begin with. His *only* job was to format everything!”

“Yeah, well,” Sophia shrugs, “I’m just the messenger.”

“Fine,” Phainon spits out, grabbing his bag and angrily slinging it over his shoulder. “Send it over and I’ll finish it tonight. I’m not wasting my weekend working on it either.” He’s also not failing this class because his teammates are all incompetent and lazy.

“Great!” Sophia squeals, patting him on the shoulder this time before hightailing it out of the room.

His glare follows her until the door slams shut, where it turns into a budding headache instead. He scowls, rubbing his temples as he tries to keep his breathing under control.

[4:47 pm] Mydei :

Are you still coming to the library today?

Mydei.

Phainon’s heart plummets straight to his stomach the second he sees the message. His breath catches, eyes beginning to feel suspiciously warm as frustration fills him. The day had already been an absolute disaster, a never-ending stream of minor inconveniences and outright catastrophes piling on top of each other like some cruel joke at his expense.

And now this.

The realisation hits like a gut punch - he completely forgot. The promise he made, the *one* thing he actually had to look forward to today, was swept aside in the chaos of missed alarms, scolding professors and vending machine betrayals.

[4:48 pm] Phainon:

i’m so sorry i forgot

i’m stuck doing a group project rn, not sure when i’ll be done

when do you finish?

[4:48 pm] Mydei :

I do a hand-over with Anaxa at 7 pm.

Don’t worry, we can meet another time.

But Phainon doesn’t *want* to meet another time. He wants to meet today, to see Mydei and read through the books that he’d picked out just for him.

[4:49 pm] Phainon:

i can do 7 if i really focus lol

[4:50 pm] Mydei :

Don’t push yourself, fool. Just keep me updated.

Phainon smiles. There, between the insult and blunt words, he can see it: *care*. If nothing else, Mydei cares for him. It’s enough for now.

[4:50 pm] Phainon:

sure thing, i’ll meet u outside the library?

[4:50 pm] Mydei :

Okay.

Phainon chucks his phone onto his desk as he links his fingers together, pushing them outwards to crack his knuckles. Time to get working.

Phainon throws himself into his work with a single-minded determination, furiously cross-checking sources and fine-tuning the PowerPoint. His fingers fly across the keyboard, correcting formatting errors, rewording awkward sentences and making sure every single slide is as polished as it can be. The effort is tedious, his eyes burning from the strain of staring at his screen for far too long, but eventually - *finally* - he’s done.

With a relieved sigh, he attaches the updated file and sends it off to the group chat. Within seconds, an onslaught of crying emojis and prayer hands flood in, souring his mood even more. He doesn’t bother reading the messages past that, muting the chat without hesitation.

Right now, there’s only one thing on his mind: Mydei. He checks the time and immediately swears under his breath - 6:55 pm. It takes at least 10 minutes to walk to the library from his dorm, but if he starts running now, he might just about make it.

As he gathers his stuff together, throwing on a jacket and shoving his feet into his trainers, he texts Mydei.

[6:56 pm] Phainon:

sorry just finished ppt

will be there soon

As soon as it is delivered, he shoves his phone into his bag and hightails it out of his room, barely remembering to shut the door behind him.

For the second time today, Phainon tears through the campus, legs burning as he sprints towards the library. His breath comes out in sharp, uneven gasps, the evening air biting at his flushed skin. His trainers slap against the

pavement, the sound drowned out by the rush of blood in his ears and the single, desperate thought looping in his head: *don't be late*.

As the library comes into view, his frantic pace slows into something closer to a stagger. His limbs feel heavy, his lungs protesting the sudden burst of exertion, but none of that matters because Mydei is right there, standing outside, *waiting* for him.

Mydei is alone, his face bathed in the soft, bluish glow of his phone screen. He doesn't have his glasses on this time, which is new. His posture is relaxed, one hand tucked into the pocket of his coat, his attention fixed downward. For a brief moment, Phainon panics and worries that Mydei is going to be mad at him for keeping him out in the cold because of his poor time management.

But then Mydei looks up at his arrival, eyes wide and doe-like, lips parted as he watches Phainon stumble the last few steps, practically collapsing forward as he braces his hands against his knees in an attempt to catch his breath. His chest heaves, air burning his nostrils, vision swimming slightly from the exertion.

"Gods," He pants between gasps, eyes squeezing shut. "I think - I think I just saw my life flash before my eyes."

"Ever the dramatic one," Mydei says lightly.

“I’m really sorry,” Phainon apologises. “I lost track of time. My teammates -”

“It’s okay,” Mydei cuts him off.

Phainon deflates at the dismissal and stands up straight, finally having caught his breath. His vision blurs for a second, something tickling his face as he realises a stray strand of hair has fallen across his eyelashes. He blinks rapidly, trying to dislodge it, but it stubbornly clings on. With an irritated huff, he lifts a hand to brush it away, but before he can, another hand moves first.

A featherlight touch sweeps across his face, tucking the strand away before his fingers even make it past his shoulder. His breath stutters as Mydei’s fingers barely graze his skin, but it’s enough - enough to send a current of something sharp and electric straight through him. His entire body stills, frozen, eyes widening as he looks up to find Mydei already watching him. The usual sharpness in Mydei’s expression is absent, replaced with something soft and intent, like he’s studying a delicacy. Mydei’s fingers linger for just a fraction longer than necessary, a fleeting moment where neither of them moves, where the space between them vibrates with a quiet, unbearable tension.

Phainon swallows, his throat suddenly dry. The world feels strangely distant - just the two of them standing there, the library doors behind them, the air cool against Phainon’s still overheated skin.

“...Thanks,” Phainon says, voice lower than usual.

Mydei blinks, his fingers curling slightly before it falls back to his side.

“You didn’t have to run here, I would’ve waited for you regardless,” Mydei says.

“But -” Phainon coughs, slightly out of breath once again. “I didn’t want you to wait.”

Mydei tilts his head, lips pressing together in something like amusement. “And why’s that?”

Phainon exhales sharply, still feeling the burn of his sprint in his lungs. He rolls his shoulders and straightens his back as if that’ll make him look less affected.

“Because,” Phainon starts, a little hoarse. “I already feel bad enough for forgetting. I didn’t want to make you stand around on top of that.”

“It’s not a big deal.”

“It is to me,” Phainon counters, too fast, too earnest.

Mydei sighs, long-suffering like he’s entertaining the antics of a particularly unruly child. His fingers move before Phainon can react, flicking him right in the middle of his forehead. The touch is light, nothing like the sharp, teasing flick from the cafe days ago.

“You’re out of breath, red in the face, and sweating through your shirt,” Mydei’s voice is impossibly steady, but there’s a faint quirk to his lips despite reading Phainon for filth. “It’s cute.”

Phainon freezes. His brain short-circuits. The words don’t register at first, but when they do, heat floods his face; he's surprised he doesn’t combust on the spot.

“...What?” He croaks.

Mydei shrugs, casual as anything. “I said it’s cute.”

Phainon can do nothing but stare because Mydei just said that. Out loud. Like it’s normal. Like it’s nothing.

“How is any of that *cute*?” Phainon says in disbelief. If anything, all the stuff Mydei just listed should be grounds to be friend-dumping him and walking away this instant.

“Because it’s you,” Mydei replies simply.

“You - you can’t just say things like that,” Phainon splutters, feeling himself spiralling.

“Why not?” Mydei’s smirk is subtle, but it’s there, and *oh*, Phainon is in so much trouble.

Mydei is playing with him, testing him. And worse, it’s working.

“Because I’ll get the wrong idea,” Phainon mutters, not brave enough to voice it loudly.

Mydei eyes him up, silent and assessing, and Phainon can’t tell if he heard it or not.

“Let’s go, it’s getting cold,” Mydei says, and Phainon is relieved he wasn’t asked to repeat what he’d said.

They fall quickly into step beside each other, the soft rhythm of their footsteps the only sound between them. The night air is refreshing now that Phainon isn’t running about everywhere, and he relishes in the crispness of it as he breathes in deeply. The occasional street lamp flickers overhead as they pass beneath, its glow casting long shadows that stretch and shrink with each step.

Phainon walks without thinking, drawn forward simply by Mydei's presence at his side. It isn't until several minutes have passed that the realisation dawns on him, the cityscape unfamiliar - he has no idea where they're going. He sneaks a glance at Mydei, who seems perfectly at ease, hands tucked into his pockets, gaze fixed ahead as if he has a destination in mind.

"Uh… are we actually going somewhere? Or are we just wandering around aimlessly?"

"We're going back to my place," Mydei responds.

Phainon bites down on the inside of his cheek, a last-ditch effort to keep himself from blurting out something utterly foolish. However, no amount of restraint can stop the thoughts running rampant in his mind, each one more suggestive than the last. Phainon, in Mydei's personal space. Mydei, who is currently walking them back to his place. Above everything else, though, he's intrigued.

"We are?" Phainon's voice trembles. "I thought we'd go to the cafe or something."

"The cafe doesn't have what I want to show you."

Phainon internally groans, anticipation flooding his system as he continues to follow Mydei.

Mydei’s apartment is nothing like Phainon expected, yet at the same time, it fits him perfectly. The space is open and elegant, with every detail carefully curated. Deep, rich wooden floors stretch across the room, polished to a subtle sheen that catches the glow of the lamps. Red accents punctuate the space - a throw draped over the back of a sleek leather sofa, the spines of well-worn books stacked neatly on dark oak shelves, and the curtains draped across the windows.

Everything is sleek, modern, yet undeniably lived-in. There’s no sterile perfection - a used mug placed next to an open book on the coffee table, a jacket chucked over the arm of the sofa - it’s a place that is used and appreciated. The air within carries a faint mix of bergamot and something slightly sweeter, something distinctly Mydei.

Phainon barely hesitates before making himself at home. He toes off his shoes, shrugging off his jacket to place on the coat peg next to the door, and waltzes right on in.

“This is nice,” Phainon says absentmindedly, still trying to take everything in. His eyes trace the endless lines of books on the shelving units, seemingly covering up the majority of wall space available.

“I didn’t say you could make yourself at home,” Mydei replies snidely, but there’s no bite to it as he follows behind. “What I want to show you isn’t in here, it’s on my balcony.”

Phainon whips around, “You have a *balcony*?”

“Adult with a job, remember?” Mydei jeers.

Mydei brushes past him, shoulders touching, leaving a trail of something sweet and tart in his wake. The soft brush of fabric and the quiet press of their footsteps against the plush rug are the only sounds as they cross the room. Without hesitation, Mydei reaches for the heavy red curtains that frame one wall, their deep colour rich and striking even in the low light. With a swift motion, he pulls them apart, revealing the glass doors behind them. The dark reflection of the room disappears as he slides one open, letting the chilly night air in.

The cold is immediate, infiltrating the warm apartment like an uninvited guest. Phainon follows, stepping onto the balcony with a quiet inhale, the chill biting at his skin. The wind is sharper up here, tugging insistently at his clothes, and ruffling his hair no matter how many times he tries to smooth it down again. The space is small, barely big enough for a simple pair of garden chairs and a circular table. Phainon is drawn immediately to the glass railing, peering over it with curiosity as he takes in the sprawling city beneath, a multitude of coloured lights scattered across the darkness.

Above, the sky is vast and clear, the moon casting a silver light over everything it touches. Phainon looks over his shoulder to point it out to Mydei, but the other man is already looking skyward, expression muted and almost reverent, caught in the view as if it’s revealing a secret only he can understand.

“I thought you were going to show me some books?” Phainon asks quietly.

Mydei tears his eyes away from the moon, “I have something better than that.” He walks over to the right corner of the balcony, gesturing.

Phainon frowns at his words but looks, eyes immediately widening when he realises what Mydei is showing him. A *telescope*.

He runs up to it, fawning over the white and black metal, hands hovering just above it so as to not touch it without permission. “This is so cool!”

Mydei sidles up beside him, bringing warmth with the gentle press of their bodies together. He adjusts the position of the telescope slightly. “You can see Orion through it if you want.”

Phainon nods enthusiastically, stepping forward and bending down to peer through the eyepiece. At first, all he sees is darkness, the lens revealing nothing but an unfocused void. He blinks, adjusting to the narrow frame of vision. Then, slowly, the sky sharpens before him, and there it is - Orion, no longer just an abstract pattern against the vast night, but something tangible. It’s so much better than seeing it on a phone screen or in a textbook. He pulls back, breath creating puffs of steam in front of him.

“It’s beautiful,” Phainon comments, voice quiet.

“Mhm,” Mydei nods. He lifts an arm to point towards the sky, “There it is.”

Phainon follows his direction, and it’s there again, crystal clear in the sky. The three stars of Orion’s Belt stand out immediately, aligned in a perfect row like stepping stones in the sky. They burn with a steady brilliance even from so far away, distinct and unwavering against the inky blackness. Around them, more stars emerge.

“What’s that one?” Phainon asks, pointing to a bright star nearby.

“Betelgeuse,” Mydei answers. He raises his arm again, tracing a pattern in the sky, linking up all the stars into a shape. “Rigel, Bellatrix, Saiph,” He lists out, moving as he goes to show the positions. “Orion’s Nebula.”

Phainon exhales, utterly captivated by the way Mydei speaks, by the quiet knowledge in his voice as he names each star as if he holds entire galaxies within himself. The vastness of it all settles over Phainon like a heavy weight - the endless stretch of the universe, the insignificance of his own existence in comparison, and yet, against all odds, here he is: standing beside Mydei, sharing this fleeting moment in the luminescence of stardust. He wishes he could capture it somehow - bottle up the warmth of Mydei’s presence, the way his voice shapes the cosmos into something intimate, something knowable. He wants to cradle this feeling in his hands, tuck it away safely like a fragile ember, so that no matter how much time passes, it will always burn brightly in his mind.

“Do you stargaze every night?” Phainon asks when Mydei is finished listing the names of the stars.

“Only when I feel like it,” Mydei replies. “Most of the time, it’s too cloudy.” He shifts then, not further away but closer, pressing their shoulders together more firmly. “I’ve never shared this with anyone else before.”

Phainon’s breath catches in his throat, heart stuttering and then starting again. His stomach floods with butterflies, their wings as gentle as dandelion seeds in the wind. “Then, I’m glad you shared it with me.”

Mydei hums softly in response, not saying anything else. Phainon becomes acutely aware of the space - or lack thereof - between them. Their shoulders brush with every small movement, their faces tilted inwards, no longer facing the sky but each other, drawn together by something unspoken. Phainon swallows, the clicking of his throat loud in the silence as he meets Mydei’s gaze, watching the way the moonlight spills over his features like the finest of silk, making his amber eyes glow a molten gold. Ethereal, otherworldly - a sight so mesmerising that Phainon physically cannot look away. It’s different than witnessing the stars in the sky, their tiny bodies full of hot gas because somehow, Mydei burns brighter than them all combined.

The wind tousles Mydei’s hair, strands whipping across his forehead in a way that should be chaotic but only makes him look even more effortlessly beautiful. His nose is tinged with pink from the cold, his lips slightly parted, and Phainon has never wanted anything more than to close the remaining distance between them. It would take so little to reach out, to touch, to take - but Phainon holds himself still, caught in the moment, drinking it in, afraid that if he moves the spell will break.

He’s beautiful.

He’s everything that Phainon wants.

Yearning crashes into him, sudden and all-consuming, like a tidal wave pulling him under. The vastness of the night sky stretches endlessly above them, making him feel impossibly small in the grand scheme of the universe. And yet, here - right here, on Mydei’s balcony, standing a few inches taller, close enough to feel the warmth radiating from him despite the chill in the air - he feels larger than life. Every emotion swirling inside him is too big, too intense, filling the spaces between his ribs until he swears he might burst. Each emotion is because of Mydei, *for* Mydei. His presence grounds him and sets him adrift all at once.

Without thinking, moving as slowly as he can, he raises a hand, cupping Mydei’s cheek in his palm. It’s cold to the touch but quickly warms up with his body temperature.

“You’re cold,” Phainon whispers idly, wondering why Mydei isn’t shoving him away yet.

Instead, Mydei allows it, head tilting slightly into the touch. It’s delicate, warm and precious, but most of all, *permission*. It feels as though Phainon is holding the entire world and solar system within his hands. Mydei looks up at him through his blonde lashes, and they’re so close that if Phainon wanted to, he could count each one lining Mydei’s eyes.

One, two, three, he begins, keeping in time with his shallow breathing.

Four, five, six, he continues, and he can tell the exact moment that Mydei begins to smile just by the way his eyes curve upwards sweetly. Their noses bump together, but Mydei doesn't flinch or tell him to stop. He keeps watching, his gaze saccharine, even as their breaths begin to mingle from their close proximity.

Seven, Phainon inches closer, their noses slotting against each other.

"I really like you, Mydei."

Eight, Mydei angles his head slightly up, foreheads touching.

"I… like you, too."

Nine, Phainon inhales deeply, finally able to pinpoint what Mydei smells like. It's pomegranate, sweet and tart.

"Are you going to kiss me or just carry on staring at me like you want to?"

Ten.

Phainon sighs with relief and swoops in, pressing their lips together gently. His eyelids fall shut so he can finally - *finally* - kiss Mydei, the culmination of months' worth of feelings overflowing. Mydei surges up like the ocean, arms coming up to wrap their way around Phainon's neck. They turn towards each other, chest-to-chest, sharing the same bubble of warmth, warding against the cold wind.

It's chaste at first, delicate and testing, their mouths barely touching. Phainon doesn't move, too afraid that it'll snap Mydei out of this daze and he'll get pushed away. But then Mydei hums, the noise vibrating between them in a way that makes Phainon's lips tickle. He sounds *content* and pleased, giving Phainon the last boost of confidence he needs to let himself go.

They begin to move, slow at first as if testing the waters, learning the shape of each other in a language spoken only through touch. Phainon repositions himself, tilting his head so he can get the angle just right to slot his bottom lip between Mydei's. It deepens the kiss and his fingers twitch at his sides before he gives in, reaching out, grasping at the fabric of Mydei's shirt. It's soft beneath his fingertips, but not as soft as Mydei himself - warm and pliant, meeting him halfway with a sigh that Phainon swears he'll replay in his head a thousand times over.

The world around them begins to fade, dissipating into nothingness as the sky and city below become nothing but background noise. All that exists now is the heat between them, and the way Mydei's fingers find their place tangled up in the short hairs at the nape of Phainon's neck, the grip steadying. A shiver rolls down his spine that has nothing to do with the cold

but all to do with the way that Mydei is kissing him - each press of their lips deliberate, like he means it, like he’s wanted this just as much as Phainon has. The thought makes his head spin, the base of his neck tingling when Mydei tugs just *so* at his hair, his back arching. It presses them closer, not an inch between them from their chests to their knees as Phainon swallows the quiet, breathless noises that Mydei makes, his heart thrumming wildly with each one.

When they finally part, it’s only by a fraction, just enough for Phainon to catch his breath, to take in the sight of Mydei - lips swollen, eyes half-lidded, a soft, dazed expression on his face. He can’t help himself, now he’s gotten a taste, Phainon never wants to stop. He lets go of Mydei’s shirt to cup his cheeks, dragging him in for another kiss.

This time, there’s no semblance of gentleness left. Phainon swipes his tongue against Mydei’s bottom lip, immediately licking straight into his mouth as soon as Mydei opens up for him. It drags a groan out of them both as their tongues touch. Mydei tastes *good*, sweet and minty as if he’s just been chewing on gum. It’s addicting, making his mouth water as Phainon grips at Mydei’s slim waist, pulling him impossibly closer. There’s nothing tentative about this - not anymore. It’s messy, needy, fuelled by all the tension that had been simmering between them for weeks. Phainon doesn’t care - all he cares about is the way Mydei is kissing him back just as fiercely, just as desperate, fingers curled into his hair, tugging at them with each gasp and whine.

“Inside,” Mydei says between kisses, voice hoarse and *wrecked*.

Phainon pulls away long enough to nod, perhaps too enthusiastically, “Yeah.”

They stumble back inside, still tangled in their kiss, Phainon following Mydei blindly, only the hands on his hips guiding him. Phainon bumps into a table, his hip catching the back of the sofa, almost tripping over the rug, but nothing can break the connection between them. His fingers fumble desperately at the hem of Mydei's shirt, tugging at it incessantly, silently pleading.

Mydei pulls away just enough to yank the shirt over his head, tossing it carelessly somewhere in the room. Phainon doesn't even glance at it, his eyes fixated on the intricate red tattoos that swirl across Mydei's torso. The artwork is mesmerising, following the natural curve of his body in perfect harmony. Phainon reaches out, his fingertip lightly brushing the ink, tracing its path over Mydei's pec, down across his ribs, and disappearing behind his back. He watches in fascination as his touch leaves a ripple of goosebumps in their wake. It's more beautiful than Phainon could have imagined, every line and swirl like a story written just for him to read.

It's only when Mydei reaches out for him, hands grasping at his t-shirt, pulling it up that he gets the hint and raises his arms to allow Mydei to remove it fully. His t-shirt shares a similar fate to Mydei's, being tossed aimlessly across the room. Phainon stands there, his skin slowly warming up with the heat from being back inside to Mydei's hot gaze trailing across his exposed body. He almost feels shy, like he should cover himself up - his body is nothing compared to Mydei's, after all, but the way he's being looked at: hungrily, as though Mydei is drinking him bit by bit, makes him preen instead.

"You're -"

“Bedroom,” Mydei cuts him off, grabbing his hand and threading their fingers together as he’s pulled along again, further into the apartment until they reach a closed door.

Mydei opens it, flicking on the light, and Phainon takes what little time he has before Mydei is back on him again, kissing, hands plastering themselves against his body, to look around the room. The room is regal, with a massive bed in the centre of the back wall, the colour scheme rich and dark with burgundies and browns. A large, intricately carved wooden wardrobe stands to the side while a velvet armchair sits near the window, adding a touch of luxury.

Mydei grumbles, clearly sensing Phainon’s distraction, and gives him a firm shove. Phainon stumbles, the force sending him reeling until the backs of his knees collide with the edge of the bed. A finger hooks underneath the waistband of his jeans, tugging at it.

“Off,” Mydei commands, and who is Phainon to deny?

Phainon can barely keep upright as his knees begin to shake and undoes his fly, shimmying out of his jeans until they pool at his ankles. He kicks them off, watching raptly as Mydei unbuckles his belt, the clinking of metal against leather loud in the silence of the room. Before he can reach out and help, another shove, and he sits down on the bed with a soft bounce, barely getting the chance to catch himself as Mydei begins to move forward.

Eyes wide, Phainon shuffles further onto the bed, scrambling until the cool wood of the headboard presses against his bare shoulders. Mydei follows

with steady, deliberate steps, first placing his hands on the mattress, then his knees. Like a predator, he crawls forward, clad in only his boxers, his gaze fixed, movements slow and languid as he closes the distance between them.

“Ah, Mydei, um -” Phainon stutters as he suddenly has a lap full of Mydei.

Phainon’s eyes widen comically large, panic and excitement mixing as his heartbeat thunders in his ears, almost drowning out everything else. He holds his hands up awkwardly, trying to avoid touching Mydei, unsure of where to place them. Phainon wants to touch him everywhere: his neck, his chest, or his toned stomach. Mydei’s thick thighs rest across Phainon’s lap, the muscles flexing and shifting beneath the taut skin, and Phainon can’t help but feel the intoxicating heat of their proximity, his cock twitching in his underwear. He gulps, almost dizzy from how hard he is and with the rush of sensations going on, his joints lock up. Phainon’s mind races, trying to adjust to the weight of Mydei on top of him.

A finger snaps him out of it, sliding gently under his chin, lifting his head back up, forcing their gazes to lock. Mydei’s eyes are intense, especially considering he’s not wearing his glasses today, darkened with something fierce and possessive. Then, fingers entwine with his, bringing them down to rest on Mydei’s shoulders.

“You can touch me,” Mydei says, letting go of Phainon’s hands.

Phainon wants to savour this, to memorise every inch of Mydei beneath his hands. He starts slowly, fingertips ghosting over the broad slope of his

shoulders, following the defined lines of his biceps, feeling the subtle flex of muscle beneath warm skin. His palms skim lower, dragging reverently over the firm plane of Mydei's chest until his hands settle over his pecs. He squeezes, experimentally at first, but the give beneath his fingers is intoxicating. Phainon wets his lips as soft muscle tenses and yields under his touch, and something about it makes a deep satisfaction curl in his stomach. He kneads, pressing harder, watching how the flesh pools slightly between his fingers before bouncing back. The urge to mark Mydei overtakes him - his fingers itching and his mouth-watering with the need to press deep enough to leave imprints, to brand his presence onto him like another layer of ink woven into the red swirls of his tattoos.

Red and blue, just like them. Opposites, companions, lovers. Bound together in a way that is both fleeting and infinite, like the colours of a bruise blooming beneath the skin.

"Tell me what you want," Phainon begs because he wants too much. His chest rises and falls too quickly, breathing shallow. He needs direction, permission, something to anchor him in the storm of his own longing. He searches Mydei's face, looking for an answer, a sign, *anything*.

Hands cup his cheeks, squishing them together playfully until his lips pucker up.

"I want you to fuck me." Simple, to the point.

It's exactly what Phainon needed to hear. He breathes out, "I can do that," Phainon replies, words slightly garbled.

Mydei lets him go easily. Phainon glances down at their crotches, noting that they're both hard in their boxers, straining obviously against the material. He abandons Mydei's pecs to slide his hands further down, trailing over each ridge of his abs, dipping slightly into his belly button, relishing in the shiver it gets from Mydei. His happy trail is thick, as blonde as his hair, disappearing into the waistband of his underwear. As Mydei did to him earlier, Phainon slips a finger underneath, pulling the elastic out just enough to let it ping back. The sharp sting makes Mydei jump, a frown appearing on his face.

Phainon smiles smugly, "Let's get you out of these."

"You too," Mydei says, voice strained as he raises on his knees, shucking his underwear down his thighs as far as they can go.

Phainon focuses back on himself, shuffling out of his underwear as he watches Mydei do the same. Before long, they're back pressed against each other, completely nude with nothing in between them. Their freed cocks bump against each other, sending a shiver through Phainon as he grasps at their joint lengths to hold them steady. They both gasp at the same time with the touch, Phainon's hands cold against the heat. Mydei feels like hot steel clad in silk, thick and heavy, red and wet at the tip.

Phainon sighs dreamily, thumbing at the head just to feel the slide of precum. Mydei shuffles closer, hands on his shoulders to keep him steady as Phainon begins to work his wrist, up and down, twisting at the top before loosening as he gets to the base. He squeezes, watching the tips of their cocks disappear and reappear in the middle of his tight fist. Mydei shudders

against him, little gasps and *ah* s escaping his lips with each pump, his pace slow and measured.

“Phainon,” Mydei gasps before falling forward, fingertips digging bruisingly into his shoulders as he buries his face into the crook of his neck.

“Too much?” Phainon asks, using his clean hand to brush the length of Mydei’s hair out the way so he can press kisses to his neck. He leaves little nips along the way, making sure to soothe over them with his tongue.

Phainon doesn’t stop, slow down or speed up. He keeps going, fingers getting wetter with their precum as it eases the slide even more, his stomach burning.

“Stop, stop - ‘m gonna cum,” Mydei slurs into his neck, the words muffled.

Phainon hears, stopping immediately. He pouts, “Already?”

Mydei doesn’t move, his shoulders shaking lightly. Phainon can feel the vibrations of words spoken into his skin, but they’re too quiet to be heard. He reaches up to thread his fingers into Mydei’s hair, giving it a gentle tug and encouraging him to pull back. When he does, Phainon’s heart almost gives out. He’s flushed, eyes dewy and lips spit-slick and bitten.

He’s *divine,* like a god. One that Phainon would worship every day for the rest of his life if he’s allowed.

“Shut up,” Mydei retorts weakly, reaching over to the side of his nightstand, and grabs a bottle of lube from the drawer.

He shoves it at Phainon who takes it without question.

“If I’m going to come, it’ll be on your cock. Got it?” Mydei says, cutting and strong, just like how Phainon knows him the best.

Phainon gulps, “Got it.”

It’s hard concentrating on slicking his fingers up with lube when he’s got a lap full of Mydei, already writhing in place with wandering hands and a curious mouth. Phainon lets his head fall back, grip loosening on the bottle as Mydei licks a strip up his neck, nibbling at the hinge of his jaw, breath coming in hot puffs that leave condensation in their wake. It doesn’t stop, not even as he parts Mydei’s ass cheeks and slides a finger down until it reaches the furl of muscle. Mydei jolts, breath stuttering, but then he’s carrying on, allowing Phainon to press in further, so good and so hot around him until he reaches the first knuckle.

“Hurry up,” Mydei grumbles, already pushing back on the single finger.

“What if I wanna take my time with you, hm?” Phainon asks, nuzzling into the side of Mydei’s head, inhaling the citrus scent of his shampoo, but he soon slots a second finger in.

“You don’t need to treat me like I’m delicate,” Mydei chastises, but he sounds breathless, hips jerking and rolling.

“Maybe not,” Phainon curls his fingers, smirking when Mydei moans loudly, hips shaking at the graze against his prostate. “But you’re precious.”

“Don’t say stupid shit like that,” Mydei curses, swallowing thickly, his cock twitching.

Phainon smothers a laugh, biting down on his bottom lip to keep it from slipping free. Mydei is so easy to read like this, his expression is completely open, with no trace of his usual guardedness. His amber eyes are dark with want, wide and pleading, every emotion laid bare between them. It’s like he was *made* for this, to be opened up and spread wide, preparing for Phainon. There’s minimal resistance when Phainon puts in a third finger, scissoring them open and closed, pulling out to the tips of his nails and pushing back into the top of his palm.

“Enough, enough!” Mydei snaps after being worked open on Phainon’s fingers for minutes on end.

“Sure?” Phainon asks, kissing Mydei’s cheek, nosing at his temple.

A hand wraps around his wrist, yanking his fingers out without a verbal response. Mydei's chest is heaving, flushed up to the roots of his hair as he grabs for Phainon's cock, holding it steady as he slicks it up and tries to line it up with his rim. Phainon's hands clutch at Mydei's waist, holding him as he watches determination pinch at his expression. It's horribly endearing, even more so when Mydei fails the first few tries. He's too tightly wound, the head of Phainon's cock dipping in slightly before slipping past. Mydei grunts in frustration, but Phainon doesn't interfere just yet, too caught up in the show unfolding in front of him.

"Relax," Phainon croons eventually, hands sliding down over the curve of his waist to grope at his ass, pulling his cheeks wide.

"Wh -!" Mydei gasps, allowing Phainon to guide him until the tip finally catches, sinking in a few inches.

They both groan in relief, Mydei's hands flying to grapple at Phainon's shoulders for support. Phainon winces as nails dig into his skin, surely leaving crescent-shaped dents that will take hours to go back to normal. He doesn't care, not when Mydei's eyes flutter, lips parting on a whine as he slides further down Phainon's cock, tight and burning hot around him. Mydei feels so *good*, letting him in so easily until he's fully seated on Phainon's lap, buried all the way to the hilt.

"Holy fuck, Mydei," Phainon gasps out, "You're perfect, so good, so *tight*, you feel -"

“Shut *up*!” Mydei snaps, shuddering.

“You like that?” Phainon asks, leaning forward to place his chin in between Mydei’s pecs, looking up at him. “Like being told that you’re *good*,” Phainon presses a quick kiss to his sternum before drifting to the left, “That you feel amazing around me,” He licks the breadth of his tongue across Mydei’s nipple, toes curling in pleasure when Mydei clamps down around his cock in response. “That you’re pretty, stunning…” A bite, this time, hard enough to leave teeth marks. “That I’ve wanted you since the moment we met?”

“*Shut -*” Mydei’s voice breaks, unable to finish his sentence when Phainon uses his grasp on his ass to move him upwards, bullying him to almost pull off his cock entirely. He stops when he reaches the tip, keeping the head inside.

“C’mon, Mydei,” Phainon urges, guiding Mydei back down, his cock sliding easily through the mess of lube covering it and inside, squelching obscenely when he’s back inside. “Don’t you wanna prove me right?”

Mydei’s back arches deliciously as he’s stretched full once again, mouth wide open and head thrown back. A line of drool escapes his mouth, dripping down his chin and over his jawline, following a path down his neck before pooling in the dip of his collarbone. Phainon follows it from start to finish, eyes burning with hunger and desire. He lets go of Mydei’s ass, placing one hand on his waist as the other comes up to cup Mydei’s sweat-damp cheek. It’s sweet how easily Mydei leans into it, allowing Phainon to rub his thumb absentmindedly across his bottom lip, dipping the tip between to feel the heat of his mouth. He tugs at the corner of his lips, more drool leaking out with it, following the same path as before. Phainon

narrows his eyes when Mydei closes his lips around his thumb, sucking gently at it.

“You really are perfect,” Phainon comments, exploring Mydei’s mouth, feeling the ridges of his teeth and the undulating movement of his tongue swirling around his thumb. He hooks it behind the row of teeth at the front, using it to pull Mydei forward and into him, their foreheads almost knocking together.

Phainon removes his thumb, replacing it with his mouth, kissing Mydei once again. He swallows every whine, every whimper, every moan and failed attempt at saying his name as Mydei begins to move, up and down, faster and faster until he’s riding Phainon without abandon. Their kiss turns sloppy, mostly made up of panting and moans as they exert themselves. Phainon’s hips twitch upward, meeting Mydei halfway each time, the sound of their skin slapping together noisy in the quietness of the night.

Phainon is determined to get his hands on every part of Mydei that he physically can. They travel along his body, an endless journey with no stopping point, moving around from place to place without really settling. His face, his neck, his shoulders and back, his pecs that are swollen from being grabbed and his nipples that are sore from being pinched. The plane of his abs, his waist, to his hips that have bruises already forming in the shape of his fingertips. Phainon even smooths his palms up and down the taut muscle of Mydei’s working thighs, massaging them to feel the pure power beneath.

“You’re doing so well,” Phainon pants into Mydei’s mouth. “I’m so close.”

Mydei nods, scrunching his eyes shut as his thighs tremble with exertion. Phainon has no idea how long they've been going at it, the span of time between them feeling endless and simultaneously not enough. Sweat slicks their skin, rivulets of it dripping down Mydei's body and over his chest, practically begging Phainon to taste. He does, licking it up and lapping at Mydei's nipples, worrying the hard nubs between his teeth, sucking and kissing them.

"Phainon, I -" Mydei cuts off, curling inwards on himself.

"I got you," Phainon replies, wrapping a hand around Mydei's cock. It twitches and jerks in his grasp, completely soaked from how much Mydei has leaked all over himself.

A few languid slides later and Mydei is clamping down around him, shuddering and convulsing, back bowed and mouth and eyes wide open as he comes over Phainon's fist, hot spurts of come wetting the skin and splashing against both of their stomachs. Watching Mydei come is like watching a supernova, beautiful and awe-inspiring. Mydei slumps against Phainon, coming down from his high in tiny swivels of his hips and the jolting of his shoulders, clearly still experiencing tiny sparks of pleasure that light him up from within. Phainon wraps his arms around him, pulling him closer, pressing delicate kisses to wherever he can reach, whispering praises and sweet nothings into his ears.

With nothing more than a protesting whimper, Phainon switches their places until Mydei is lying on his back, lounging amongst his pillows as Phainon looms over him.

“I know, I know,” Phainon placates as he begins moving again, fucking into Mydei to chase his own high. Mydei doesn’t stop him, instead pressing back into the thrusts, his soft cock giving a valiant twitch at the stimulation.

He curves over Mydei as if shielding him from the rest of the world, burying his cock in as far as he can go until he comes, shuddering and moaning with the release. He’s careful not to collapse fully onto the man beneath, instead holding himself up on shaking arms until he’s ready to pull out. They both wince as he does, his come flowing out, staining the bed sheets.

“Ah, shit, lemme go grab you a towel,” Phainon says, making a move to get off the bed.

A hand stops him, grabbing onto his forearm. “I have tissues,” Mydei jerks his chin towards his nightstand.

Phainon grabs a few and cleans Mydei up as gently as possible, chucking the used ball of tissues into the rubbish bin on the other side of the room. Thankfully, it lands inside, not missing the shot. He flops down beside Mydei, watching him fondly as he wriggles beneath the duvet, offering up the space next to him to Phainon. He goes, diving in quickly and cuddling up next to him, arms wrapping around his waist to plaster against his side.

He gets a shove for it. “You’re sweaty.”

“So are you,” Phainon replies, nuzzling into Mydei regardless.

Mydei sighs, defeated, and lets himself be cuddled. Phainon laughs, kissing his cheek before leaning up and pressing a chaste kiss to his lips. Mydei’s eyes immediately flutter shut, and so Phainon kisses him more. It stays soft and slow, never veering into anything more than that.

Phainon doesn’t remember falling asleep after that, content and warm and with his arms full of Mydei.

Phainon stirs awake, the scent of something warm and sweet pulling him from the depths of sleep. His nose twitches as he inhales, the unmistakable aroma of butter and sugar curling in the air, mingling with the faintest hint of coffee. His stomach grumbles in response.

With a groggy sigh and a pout of disappointment that Mydei isn’t sleeping next to him, he stretches, limbs lazy and sated. He gets out of bed, searches the room for his boxers and slips them on. The cool air of the room prickles against his exposed skin as he pads towards the source of the smell, rubbing the sleep from his eyes.

The open-plan apartment is bathed in soft morning light, golden rays filtering through the large windows. In the kitchen, standing at the hob, is Mydei. Phainon stills for a moment, taking in the sight before him. Mydei is focused, flipping a pancake with effortless precision, his back turned to

him. The muscles of his shoulders and spine shift with every movement, his skin kissed by the morning glow. Then, Phainon notices with a grin, the *apron*. He tries to stifle a laugh the best he can. It’s a little ridiculous - pastel pink and far too cutesy for someone like Mydei, especially with the frilled edges and the way the ribbon cinches neatly at the waist. But there’s something undeniably endearing about the contrast of it all, the way it hangs against his bare back, leaving every inch of sculpted muscle on display.

Phainon leans against the doorway, watching for a moment longer, basking in the domesticity of it all. His chest warms at the thought - how lucky he is to have met someone like this, waking up to the smell of breakfast, to Mydei standing in the kitchen like they’ve done this a thousand times before.

Phainon doesn’t wait any longer - his feet begin to move, drawn in by the warmth, the smell and the sight of Mydei standing there. He rushes forward, arms slipping around Mydei’s waist, pressing his chest flush against the broad expanse of his bare back.

He buries his face into the space between Mydei’s shoulder blades, inhaling deeply, their touch making his body hum with satisfaction. His lips press against the firm muscle of his shoulder, then again, soft and deliberate, trailing a path of lazy kisses along the curve where his neck meets his back.

Mydei shifts, huffing as he halfheartedly tries to shrug him off, but Phainon tightens his grip, refusing to be dislodged.

“You’re in my way,” Mydei mutters, leaning forward over the frying pan as if that’ll make him let go.

Phainon ignores him and smiles against his skin, undeterred, his kisses growing more playful, nipping lightly before soothing the spot with his tongue. Mydei exhales sharply, his body betraying him as the tension in his shoulders eases, though his grumbling continues. The scent of warm honey and pancakes lingers in the air, but Phainon is far more intoxicated by the scent of Mydei himself - his skin, his warmth, the way he shifts under his touch, resisting but never truly pulling away.

“No need to be shy,” Phainon coos obnoxiously.

“I’m not *shy*,” Mydei snaps. “I’m trying to dish up our breakfast.”

Phainon pouts and reluctantly pulls away, watching Mydei plate up a fresh stack of pancakes on their plates, dusting the tops with icing sugar and garnishing with strawberries. He takes both plates in hand, directing Phainon towards the dining table where he places them down on the dinner mats already set up. There are two identical mugs already there, full of steaming hot coffee. Phainon’s mood brightens as he goes over, taking the seat next to Mydei as he digs into his breakfast.

The pancakes are *divine* - golden brown, pillowy soft, and airy enough that they practically melt on his tongue. Each bite is drenched in a generous drizzle of honeyed syrup, the sweetness coating his lips and making his taste buds sing. The edges have just the right amount of crispness, a delicate contrast to the fluffy centre.

Phainon doesn’t waste time with pleasantries; he shovels them down with enthusiasm, fork scraping against the plate as he devours every last bite. The warmth of the pancakes lingers, mixing with the smooth, slightly bitter taste of the coffee he sips to wash it all down.

He sits back in his chair, licking a stray drop of syrup from his thumb, already contemplating whether he can convince Mydei to make another batch. Instead, he’s met with Mydei watching him, eyebrows raised.

Phainon laughs nervously, “They were really good.”

“I can tell,” Mydei replies, barely even having started on his own.

“I didn’t know you could cook.”

Mydei hums, chewing and swallowing his mouthful before he speaks. “There’s still a lot of things about me you don’t know.”

“Oh?” Phainon grins, resting his elbow on the table and propping his chin up on the palm of his hand. “Better start telling me everything then, dear.”

Mydei’s face scrunches up. “Don’t call me that.”

“Sweetheart?” Phainon suggests, grabbing one of Mydei’s hands, not caring that it’s holding onto a utensil. He presses a kiss to his knuckles. “Darling?” He turns Mydei’s hand around, thumbing his fingers open until the fork falls and clatters to the table. He kisses the centre of his palm. “How about the light of my life?” He punctuates the nickname with a kiss on the inside of Mydei’s wrist this time.

Mydei’s lips are pinched, eyebrows furrowed, but he’s flushed bright pink, the colour close enough to match the shade of his apron. “I’ll kick you out if you don’t stop.”

Phainon uses his grip around his wrist to yank him forward, pulling them closer so that he can press a kiss to Mydei’s lips, sweet and sticky from the syrup.

“Sure thing… doll?”

“Phainon!” Mydei yells, and Phainon makes a run for it, running straight back into the bedroom, laughing loudly as Mydei follows right behind him.

Chapter End Notes

thanks for reading, if you enjoyed, please leave a comment and kudos!!! ヾ(≧▽≦*)o
-
let's be friends on x/twitter! i post fic updates/previews, and lots about phaidei ^_^ let's be moots
-

i'm also working on a bunch of other phaidei wips (canon au, omegaverse... fake dating au...!!!) so there's more to come soon hehe
-
i'm going to miss writing these two in this au so much, but i'm thinking of doing an epilogue type thing in mydei's pov. what do you all think?

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!